An Inquiry On Respect

By PhilosophizingDoodle

Definitions of The Inquiry

Foundations of Respect

Respect: The first created ordering principle of our universe: a timeless structural grammar that makes coherent relations, change, and intelligibility possible within a finite cosmos.

Cosmic Grammar: The structural framework through which intelligibility is possible in a universe. In our universe, this grammar is Respect.

God: The infinite, personal, and uncreated source of all reality, existing beyond time, matter, and the universe. God is the supreme fundamentality, the origin of all goodness, intelligibility, and being. God is the author of structure, not a part of it.

Universally Specific Normativity: The universe-bound necessity for finite beings to align with coherence within the structure of intelligibility that makes such alignment possible.

Logos: The infinite intelligibility of God Himself. Logos is not contingent on any universe and does not derive from finitude. It is the perfect expression of God's will and the ground of divine intelligibility.

Structural Metaphysics

Fundamentality: The degree to which something directly participates in universal coherence and is independent of lower relational conditions.

Hierarchy of Fundamentality: The ordered structure of reality in which higher levels ground the possibility of lower ones: God → Respect → Ideal One-to-One

Relation → Change → Agency → Individualized Respect.

Directness: The degree of relational immediacy between causes and effects without distortion or mediation.

Indirectness: Relational mediation that introduces distortion, fragmentation, or contradiction within causal relations.

Coherence: The directly related alignment of relations within existence, in which a cause is directly related to an effect and forms an intelligible, always mutually supportive, and stable structure. It is good because its directly aligned relations are eventually fulfilled as one unified whole, which is God.

Objective Direction: The universal tendency of relations toward greater directness and coheren**ce.**

Relations and Change

Ideal One-to-One Relation: The perfectly direct relation between two states of change in which one reflects the other without distortion.

Change: The abstract reconfiguration of relational coherences across time.

Change-as-Such: The structural tendency of change to participate in further change, forming the most fundamental timely dynamic within the universe.

Teleology: The directed orientation of change toward greater participation in universal coherence.

Finite Teleology: The manifestation of divine direction within the limited structures of time-bound existence.

Respect in Action

Mutual Respect: The relational expression of Respect within time and causality, where changes align coherently with other changes.

Relational Reciprocity: The condition in which interacting entities mutually influence each other through coherent causal relations.

Structural Stability: The persistence of relational coherence across time.

Respectfulness: The highest expression of normativity within finite structure. It is alignment with the structure of Respect that makes coherent actions possible in beings.

Agency and Moral Structure

Agency: The finite capacity, or field of possibility, of a being to influence its own trajectory of relational coherence within the structure of change.

Individualized Respect: The manifestation of primordial Respect as filtered through the choices and interpretations of conscious agents.

The Good: Transformation toward greater participation in the ideal one-to-one relation and the direction of universal coherence.

Sin: The movement of agency toward relational distortion and contradiction relative to the ideal one-to-one relation.

Alignment: The degree to which an agent's actions correspond with the objective direction of coherence.

Freedom: The capacity of an agent to untie or deepen knots within relational coherence towards a coherent end.

Structural Restoration: The process of repairing how a person's actions fit into the whole of their life and the world, so past mistakes are integrated and the person

can move toward their True Purpose. One's actions matter, but the person is not their actions.

Consciousness and Mind

External Participation: The base-layer causal coherence present in all matter and energy that enables responsiveness to external stimuli without self-awareness.

Presence: The capacity of a process of being to maintain its own coherent causal form.

Passive Directness: Direct participation in universal coherence without the possibility of deviation or choice.

Reflective Directness: Directness achieved through conscious alignment with universal coherence despite the possibility of distortion.

Consciousness: A recursively unified system capable of modeling its own participation in change.

Internal Presence: The temporally continuous capacity for unified agency, in which a being integrates possible actions into a coherent trajectory across time, regardless of variations or interruptions in awareness.

External Presence: The ability for things that lack agency to be coherent in form through external processes, such as the laws of physics.

Proto-Soul: A responsive integration of correlated relations; less reflective than an agent, but carrying the structural makeup of a soul.

The Soul

Soul: The historically unified integration of reflective directness into the causal structure of the universe that is shaped by intentional actions.

Immortality of the Soul: The persistence of the soul as the irreversible record of an agent's causal participation in reality.

Character: The stabilized historical pattern of an agent's reflective directness over time.

Evil and Distortion

Distortion: Any deviation that introduces indirectness into relations.

Evil: Structural distortion within relational coherence arising from finite deviation from the ideal one-to-one relation.

Knot (Metaphysical): A localized distortion within the universal structure of coherence.

Divided Direction: A relational state in which a system attempts to move in conflicting orientations relative to coherence.

Structural Tension: The instability that results when distortion depends on the coherence it resists.

Moral Evil: A reflective knot in which an agent knowingly deepens distortion in relational coherence.

Finite Reality

Finitude: The condition of existing within bounded structures of time, causality, and limitation.

Deviation: The capacity for finite beings to diverge from perfect relational alignment.

Structural Possibility of Evil: The inherent capacity within finite systems for distortion due to the presence of agency and deviation.

Particularity: The irreducible specificity of a being as constituted by its unique relations, boundaries, and history. A being's particularity is what makes it this being rather than merely an instance of a general kind of being.

Tragedy and Moral Conflict

Non-Reflective Knot: A knot produced by finite structural constraints rather than reflective agency, such as biological necessity, natural disasters, or instinct.

Reflective Knot: A knot generated through the deliberate deviation of reflective agency from coherent relation.

Tragedy: The collision of finite goods within the structure of reality that produces suffering without necessarily involving reflective wrongdoing.

Ethical and Existential Concepts

Flourishing: The lived experience of increasing participation in universal coherence and directness.

Responsibility: The capacity of a reflective agent to recognize, create, or untie knots within relational coherence.

Forgiveness: The act by which a reflective agent refuses to preserve a knot of resentment, protecting their own relational coherence while allowing the possibility of restoration.

Transformation: The process by which agents move toward greater fundamentality through alignment with coherence.

Normativity and Intentional Grounding

Normativity: The ‘ought’ that gives direction to reality, from the view of will itself, to what should or should not be done.

Obligation: The experienced binding force of normativity upon a reflective agent, directing the will toward coherence.

Normative Authority: The legitimate source from which obligation derives its binding force.

Structural Necessity: The causal or logical relations that determine how systems unfold within the structure of reality.

Prediction: A descriptive claim about what will occur given the causal structure of reality.

Normative Binding: The condition in which a rational agent recognizes that a certain action ought to be performed regardless of preference.

Reflective Recognition: The capacity of a reflective agent to perceive and understand normative obligation.

Ultimate Ground

Infinite Coherent Actuality: The infinite personal being whose nature is perfectly coherent and fully actualized, serving as the ultimate source of normativity, relational order, and the authority that binds rational agents.

Authority: The intentional force that binds the will, without it, obligation would be meaningless.

Address: A non-coercive, authoritative relation in which a will is confronted by a source that exceeds it and calls it to respond, whether in alignment or resistance.

Will: The actual capacity of an agent to initiate, direct, and commit to action in response to what it takes to be authoritative, and to take ownership of its actions. This capacity admits degrees, ranging from limited and fallible to perfectly coherent in its effect.

Obligated Experience: The mode of awareness in which normativity is directly encountered as a binding address rather than inferred from structure.

Traditional Experience: The mode of awareness in which normativity is mediated through interpretation, producing a separation between what is and what ought to be.

Actuality: Actuality is that which is fully determinate in itself and given as what it is, independent of partial or distorted modes of access. What is actual is what it does, or pure active intention itself.

Personality: Personality is coherent self-relation expressed as intentionality, where a will is unified in self-expression and capable of meaningful address.

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Chapter 1

The Metaphysics of Respect

Many have pondered this question: what is Respect? It is simple and mysterious, like the grace of a swan. Knowable to all, yet revealed only when conditions allow.

Respect is God's first created ordering principle, existing logically before time and matter, though not temporally prior to God. It is the foundation that makes coherent relations possible, grounding change and intelligibility. Respect does not command what ought to be. Rather, it establishes the structure within which any 'ought' emerges into our specific field of intelligibility at all.

Respect's inability to command means that Respect is not the entirety of reality, but the first created condition within a broader structure of fundamentality that descends from God into time.

Universally Specific Normativity, the 'ought' of the universe, does not originate in Respect itself. Universally Specific Normativity is the experience of alignment or misalignment with coherence within the confines of Respect, as encountered by finite agents within Respect.

It is the type of normativity that comprises the subjective, but it cannot be justifiably applied outside of our universe, which implies a lack. Therefore, God is beyond morality.

The ‘ought’ of God is not structure, but simply a pure form of normativity. In essence, Respect is not God, but it comes from God, like all things.

God exists beyond our universe, outside time itself, in a realm of infinite fundamentality. Respect, however, is contingent upon our universe and the specific arrangement of existence within it. It is finite, created to structure the relations, possibilities, and intelligibility of this cosmos. It is timeless in its structural mode, yet contingent as the grammar of our universe, depending upon God to be intended into existence as the ordering principle that coexists with time and matter.

Respect is timeless in structure but cosmically contingent. It is not locally mutable, yet it operates throughout all relations across time within our universe. From the primordial to the physical, Respect orders relations into intelligible form. It lacks time, like an idea, but its scope is limited, since Respect coheres to our specific universe, it does not expand with it. Therefore, God is prior to Respect.

Respect is not Logos. Respect is a timeless principle that exists only within our universe, whereas Logos is not contingent upon any universe. Logos exist with God as Himself. Respect is therefore a finite instantiation of Logos within a created system, shaping intelligibility as we encounter it here. Logos belong to God’s own infinite being, while Respect belongs to creation.

One can imagine a universe structured differently. Suppose a universe existed where intelligibility arose from the coexistence of infinite timelyness and finite timelyness. In such a universe, ideas themselves would unfold within time. Numbers might change, like matter changes. The number three could become six in ten years because mathematical relations would evolve alongside physical ones.

Our universe is not like this. In our universe, the number seven does not age or transform. Mathematical relations remain stable across time. Therefore,

intelligibility in our universe must arise through the coexistence of the timeless and the timely.

The intelligibility of God, however, is different. God's intelligibility is infinite. It does not depend on coexistence with anything else, because infinity lacks nothing. Logos expresses God's perfect will directly. Divine intelligibility arises not from the interaction of finitude and infinity, but from God's own coherent will.

Logos therefore operates on a different plane from Respect. Logos is the intelligibility of God's perfect will, whereas Respect is the grammar through which finite beings encounter intelligibility within creation. To understand through Respect is not to grasp God directly, but to participate in a finite reflection of divine intelligibility.

In other universes, the structuring principle analogous to Respect might differ. Logos would not. God governs the process of creation, and Respect reflects His intention rather than originating it. To walk toward Respect is like learning from a reflection: the reflection guides us toward the person it mirrors.

Respect exists timelessly, yet it coexists with time and matter, like a swan gliding across a pond. From this coexistence emerges intelligibility, just as the swan's motion becomes visible only within the water that carries it.

Because finite beings exist within time, they encounter timeless principles only through temporal experience. Numbers, truths, and goods are accessed within time even though they are not themselves temporal. Respect therefore functions as a contingent timeless principle that bridges the finite and the timeless.

Henceforth, Respect is the grammar of creation; God is the author. The words may be beyond us, but they guide us toward the author's intention.

Mutual Respect

Respect is timeless and finite. The fact that Respect is finite gives rise to the possibility of differentiation within the timeless whole of Respect.

Differentiation is the structural ‘space’ within Respect that allows things to be distinct, through Respect's own finitude. Differentiations are distinctions without interactions. These distinctions form the potential for interaction, giving rise to relation itself. Differentiations are like the ripples in a pond, formed through the grace of a swan.

These differentiations do not need time to exist, they are a consequence of finitude itself. Yet, if one were to see the whole of Respect, it will be a unity of differentiations into a singular finite timeless whole.

Time only emerges when these differentiations relate to each other, but not as the whole. This partiality forms the basis of distinguished cause and effect. Thus, as a whole, Respect is relationless because it contains all finite relations, so Respect has nothing to relate to as its whole. Respect is externally relationless, because nothing lies outside it, yet internally it contains all possible differentiations that make relation possible.

These relations are lower in fundamentality because they participate in Respect incompletely, rather than fully as the whole of it. (In this text, fundamentality most simply means the degree of direct participation in universal coherence.)

When differentiations are engaged partially rather than as a totality, they enter into relations with one another. In doing so differentiations become subject to temporality and causality, through their decoherence to the whole, which is Respect. When a differentiation becomes subject to causality, it becomes mutually related to other differentiations, and thereby mutually related to time itself.

This forms Mutual Respect: a lower fundamentality of Respect that is relational, reciprocal, and bound to causality. It is the direct alignment of change with change, producing coherence over time. This refers to abstract change understood teleologically, where change becomes self-referential, structurally unfolding toward greater participation in change-as-such.

By change-as-such, I mean change understood in its most abstract and universal form: the condition under which any relation can become another.

Change must unfold toward the conditions that make change possible rather than merely occur, because there is no higher fundamentality within time that could direct it. Change does not unfold in the sense of intention, but in the sense of structural convergence toward its own condition of possibility.

Yet, this unfolding is not self-originating. Change does not create its own direction. What appears as ‘change unfolding at itself’ is more precisely the tendency of change to unfold in accordance with the conditions that make it possible. This is the ideal one-to-one relation of perfect quality, which is prior to change.

The ideal one-to-one relation is not identical to Respect, but is the most perfect expression of it. Respect makes relation distinguishable; the ideal one-to-one relation is the point at which all relation becomes fully coherent.

It is a structural possibility of perfect coherent correspondence between differentiations. It is not an actual relation, but the condition that makes any relation, and thus change emergently possible.

The reason the ideal one-to-one relation is prior to change is that there is no change without relation between changes. If change were singular, no cause could affect anything, and the universe would cease to exist as we know it.

Therefore, the relation of change becoming change-as-such is the most fundamental point at which directness remains both timely and finite. Change participates in direction originating from higher fundamentality, but manifests within time as alignment with relational structure.

Directness is the degree of relational immediacy without distortion. It is not simplicity or lack of complexity; rather, it describes how immediately one relation corresponds to another. As relations become more direct, they tend toward a singular network of coherence, which represents the objective direction of the

universe.

This singular network is mutual by nature and therefore lacks contradiction. Contradiction arises from indirect relations, where one relation fails to correspond coherently with another. Indirectness introduces mediation and fragmentation, weakening relational coherence.

Within the directness of the universe, teleology does not emerge from temporal motion itself. The unfolding within change descends from above change, originating in God's infinite will and flowing downward through decreasing levels of fundamentality.

Change therefore participates in direction rather than inventing it. Everything within the universe can ultimately be understood as aligned with relational coherence. The rock will one day be change alone. The chickens on the farms will one day be change alone. You will be as well.

The universe unfolds toward change because there is no greater fully timely fundamentality than the alignment of change with the conditions that make it possible. It is the path of least contradiction, the finite and temporal path of least resistance.

The only structural process within time that always maintains direction is change structured by coherent relations. Anything else that exists within time depends upon change in order to exist.

While Respect is primordial and timeless, Mutual Respect exists within the unfolding universe. Mutual Respect is the relational expression of Respect in action.

Directness is essential here. The shorter the causal chain between cause and effect, the more direct the relation. Mutual Respect reflects the ideal one-to-one relation: an interaction in which one configuration of change corresponds directly to another. This relational coherence sustains the stability of the universe.

A powerful metaphor for the ideal one-to-one relation is the flame and the mirror. Imagine a flame facing a perfectly polished mirror. When the flame flickers, the mirror reflects the change exactly as it occurs. The reflection introduces nothing of its own; it merely responds to the change of the flame. This is the ideal one-to-one relation.

If the mirror becomes dirty or distorted, the reflection becomes indirect to the flame. The image fragments into complexity because the relation is no longer perfectly direct. Anything indirect, anything that deviates from the direct relation of change, risks contradiction or incoherence and therefore becomes less fundamental than its origin.

Mutual Respect is thus the engine of relational stability, while Respect is the fuel that gives Mutual Respect meaning.

Understanding change helps clarify Mutual Respect.

Mutual Respect aligns change with itself, producing higher-order stability through coherent relational participation. Without this alignment, the structure of the universe would fragment. Time requires cause and effect to exist, and Respect without coexistence with time would become a static timeless structure with no unfolding reality.

Individualized Respect

Not all relations are direct. Matter, energy, planets, and even the ground mole in your yard exist in a network of indirect relations. Individualized Respect arises when conscious agents mediate these interactions, interpreting relational conditions through their own interests and awareness.

Agency, which is the ability to direct one's own path, is central here. Agency is neither inherently good nor bad; it depends on context. Agency is the finite power of a being to derive new states of relational coherence within the structural order of

change that unfolds towards change-as-such. When an agent aligns their choices with the ideal one-to-one relation, they express the good. When they diverge toward purely self-interested paths, they move toward contradiction or sin.

This divergence is not a different direction toward the ideal one-to-one relation, but a failure to sustain direction toward it, resulting in movement toward less fundamental coherence.

The objective good is transformation towards the direction of change that structurally unfolds toward greater participation in change-as-such. Therefore, contradiction arises when distance is developed between the paths of distortion and transformation, between Individualized Respect and Mutual Respect.

Individualized Respect is therefore the manifestation of primordial Respect filtered through agency.

What agency reveals is a distinction in the degree of coherent independence between what lies above agency and what lies below it. Agency does not generate change, but operates within it; it is the selection among possible configurations of change.

Within the Hierarchy of Fundamentality, each level follows from a reduction in coherent independence and an increase in dependence on external relations. From infinite coherence in God, to created timeless but finite structure of Respect, to perfect quality in the ideal one-to-one relation, to temporal change, to the freedom of agency, and finally to distortion within individualized participation.

God → Respect → Ideal One-to-One Relation → Change → Agency → Individualized Respect (the condition for distortion and Evil).

This is the Hierarchy of Fundamentality.

This hierarchy reveals not only the structure of reality, but the varying degrees through which coherence is expressed and distorted. To understand why coherence

is good, we must now examine its role as the ground of direction, being, and fulfillment.

Coherence As The Good

The good is not separate from this hierarchy, but is the direction of ascent within it. It is an ascent upward toward greater coherence, greater directness, and greater participation in what is most fundamental.

Coherence is good not because we prefer it, nor because it produces outcomes, but because incoherence undermines the very ability of being, relation, and intelligibility. Without coherence, not even absolute nothingness can be possible. And if we can experience this absolute nothingness or even something at all, then we cannot be living in a state of absolute nothingness.

Therefore, whatever we are experiencing, it is intelligible as experience, and cannot be unintelligible. What is intelligible is to be as it is. And since absolute nothingness is impossible, to be intelligible is only possible when two or more relations support each other as a greater form than the one relation itself. If a relation cannot relate, it cannot be expressed, and not being expressed is absolutely nothing in practice. A way to understand this process is to imagine a particle without movement, it would be no particle, and the same is true for its movement in reverse.

Therefore, coherence that is directly linked with existence and what is good are one of the same. The support of the relations that makes existence evident is good because it creates. Even in perceived destruction, coherence is creating the destruction itself. The grounding of this support, or the form that gives coherence its direction and order is Respect. Respect makes the intelligibility of coherence between objects and beings possible, but it does not determine which participants can achieve coherence for themselves.

A direction toward incoherence is not a true direction, but a maze without resolution, where striving dissolves as it is pursued.

A direction requires that what is aimed at remains sufficiently identical across pursuit. If what is pursued dissolves the conditions of its own intelligibility, then it cannot be a direction, but only the collapse of direction.

If a goal cannot be understood and continually escapes us, then to strive toward it is to strive toward nothing in particular.

The good must be that which can be meaningfully pursued and sustained. If something destroys the conditions of its own pursuit, it cannot be good.

What cannot sustain direction cannot ground being. What cannot ground being cannot be good. For the good cannot undermine the very condition that allows anything to be anything at all.

Yet, even what decays does not unfold into nothingness, but transforms within relation. Even what lacks agency does not move toward incoherence; it participates in change, in erosion, in relation. If the universe moves toward coherence in its enactment, then to resist coherence is to resist the very condition that allows us to exist within it.

If the good were the abyss, then the good would be without relation, and love would not be good. Yet no one, in earnest, can deny that love is good, because love is coherence in relation.

Yet, love is not merely physical coherence, but coherence between agents in mutual recognition.

Therefore, coherence in relation is not merely a feature of the good; it is what makes anything good at all. Even the denial of coherence relies on coherence in the act of denial itself.

This reveals not only that coherence is good, but that all goodness depends upon degrees of coherent participation.

The higher something is in the Hierarchy of Fundamentality, the more directly it is related to its surroundings, and the less it depends on unstable external relations.

What is fundamental must sustain all dependent relations. If it were contradictory or unstable, what depends on it could not persist. Therefore, the more fundamental something is, the less contradiction it can contain, and thus the more coherent it must be.

Thus, what is more fundamental is more coherent, and what is more coherent is more fully good. Fundamentality is not isolation from relations, but their unification into a mutually self-sustaining state.

No finite system is purely coherent. What persists over time does so not because it is fully coherent, but because it contains enough coherence to sustain itself despite its contradictions. Where incoherence is present, it must be continually stabilized, and what must be continually stabilized is not self-sustaining. Therefore, a long-lasting tyranny does not endure by virtue of its distortions, but in spite of its distortions, and will ultimately collapse where its contradictions can no longer be sustained by the coherence within it.

The Hierarchy of Fundamentality is a triangle, with God at the top, where all relations converge toward a single point of maximal coherence. To aim at the good from the level of Individualized Respect alone is to risk becoming lost in divergence. Although, as one ascends through agency, change, and toward more fundamental relations, the path narrows toward coherence. Fundamentality is therefore not only the structure of reality, but the direction of fulfillment within it.

Why must we care about fundamentality? Because to live a good and fulfilling life, we must ascend what pulls us downward; fear, death, and our own distortions, so that we may experience the beauty of becoming more fundamental. To ground our fulfillment through abstract change itself.

When we view reality through the lens of the Hierarchy of Fundamentality, we see that change is neither infinite nor ultimate. It depends upon the ideal one-to-one relation, which itself rests within Respect. The ideal one-to-one relation is more fundamental than change, because all change is reducible to relation—one abstraction corresponding to another. Without this ultimate relation, change could not cause anything at all.

Within the universe, the Hierarchy of Fundamentality reveals itself, since no finite configuration is ultimate. Finite things can be good insofar as they participate without contradiction in what they are. Yet, they cannot maintain their own goodness because they are finite, and have some level of incoherence because of that. Therefore, something must be ultimately coherent to give source to the finite. That ultimate, within existence, is the trajectory toward directness, which draws us closer to God.

This hierarchy is sustained by God reaching downward into all that is less fundamental. For if God could not reach agency, the universe could not remain coherent, and He would not be all-powerful. Yet, the coherence of the universe reveals that this reach is real, because coherence must be sustained, not merely initiated.

God is the fullness of coherence, perfectly complete in being. All things participate in this ultimate quality by their very existence, moving toward what He possesses fully. Respect is finite, yet derives its goodness through participation in this coherence, and the ideal one-to-one relation, though finite, participates in it as well.

Because the ideal one-to-one relation and Respect contain no contradiction, their trajectories converge toward the infinite. Distortion, therefore, is movement toward the finite. It arises as a necessary result of finite participation within an infinite good.

Thus, Respect and the ideal one-to-one relation remain purely good in quality within a distorted universe. They are structurally complete, allowing agents to align with them, just as a truthful statement can perfectly correspond to reality.

God maintains the universe's coherence as the source of quantity, while we, as finite beings, use our agency to align our quality toward the infinite good, not as equals, but as reflections of that which is infinitely good.

Consciousness, Mind, and the Soul

We can see evidence for the universe being dominated by Mutual Respect by looking at the concept of time, since the aging of the brain leads to a degradation of consciousness. This is not merely speculative, but can be understood through observation of how the body's internal balance shapes the clarity of awareness. As described in research by Thomas N. Robinson and colleagues, lower levels of tryptophan after surgery have been linked with the onset of delirium in the elderly.

In an allegorical sense, tryptophan acts like a stabilizing thread that helps hold the patterns of feeling and perception together, supporting the steady currents of serotonin and melatonin. When this thread weakens, the harmony that sustains coherent awareness begins to loosen, and the structure of consciousness can lose its stability, much like a pattern that begins to unravel when its underlying supports are withdrawn.

This insight reveals that consciousness is not independent; it is causally grounded. Consciousness is tied to material processes, and therefore to time. Yet, consciousness does not merely occur in time, it requires time to exist.

If a being were paused completely in a single instant, no awareness would remain. There would be no perception of that instant, no recognition, no experience, because awareness depends on the ability to process change. Without succession, there is no relation between moments, and without relation, there is nothing to interpret.

A frozen mind is not a silent mind, but the absence of mind as such.

Consciousness is therefore not a static state, but a movement through time. It is the ongoing integration of what has just occurred with what is occurring now. It exists only across duration, never within a single point.

Consciousness depends on temporal integration, therefore consciousness is vulnerable to the conditions that sustain it. As the brain changes with age, the processes that support this temporal integration can weaken. Since tryptophan decreases over time, one might argue that consciousness and causality stand in an antagonistic relationship, where time itself erodes awareness.

Yet, consciousness is not against time, but carried by it. Causality is like a river. It does not stop. It does not forget. Every moment of awareness passes across its surface, but the flow continues regardless. Consciousness needs the river to flicker at the surface, while the current of causality beneath it remains strong and coherent.

Therefore, the antagonistic view of consciousness and causality is incomplete.

According to Edward H. F. de Haan et al., studies on split-brain patients show that consciousness can divide and reorganize itself depending on structural conditions. A subject may perform better when stimuli are presented to one hemisphere over the other, regardless of how they respond. This demonstrates that consciousness is not fixed, nor unified in itself.

Consciousness is like a lens that can crack without shattering existence. The image distorts, fragments, even duplicates, but what is behind the lens remains.

Consciousness can change. It can fragment. It can be restructured. If consciousness can fragment while existence persists, then what we are cannot be identical to the structure that fragments itself.

Therefore, consciousness cannot be the self, since the self is experienced as a holistic continuum that consciousness cannot guarantee. If consciousness can be divided, then the self must lie deeper than a being's consciousness.

Awareness may fragment, but the capacity to unify action across time can persist beneath that fragmentation.

So what is consciousness?

Consciousness emerges from a closed, structured system capable of interpreting and responding to relational conditions. Agency is found even in the simplest life forms: bacteria choose amino acids, though unconsciously. Consciousness depends on structured responsiveness, which can be understood as Mutual Respect.

Yet, beneath consciousness lies something more fundamental: External Participation.

External Participation is present in all matter and energy. It is a minimal form of presence in which constrained causality produces structured responsiveness to external stimuli, without self-reference, interpretation, or subjective awareness. In this text, presence is the ability of a process of being to be its own coherent form.

We see External Participation when a car obeys causal laws, such as being damaged in a crash. The car responds to forces without agency. It does not interpret, yet it coherently reacts. This reflects constraint-sensitive behavior, not awareness, but a minimal structural analogy to responsiveness. Brains are also causal systems, composed of the same fundamental processes of cause and effect. The difference between the awareness of the brain and the presence of the car is not fundamentality, but complexity.

A rock is struck by a rock and responds. A mind reflects what strikes the rock. The rock is shaped, but the mind interprets the shaping.

Thus, consciousness is not separate from causality. It is a higher-order organization of it.

Consciousness, or simply internal awareness, is reflective directness, or the complex causal integration of a being toward the direction through its own participation. It is alignment to the rope that must be achieved, not given. It is

integrated rather than identical to the direction; it allows for distortion, resistance, and correction.

A being is like a knot in the rope of causality. The rope is the direction itself. The knot introduces tension, curvature, and resistance.

Reflective directness is therefore the condition for agency, where one can either align with or deviate from the objective direction of the universe.

Matter, like a rock, does not demonstrate reflective directness. Instead, a rock demonstrates passive directness. Passive directness is the direction itself, change impacting change-as-such. It is purely obeying Mutual Respect, fully constrained to mutuality, incapable of deviation.

Passive directness has no internal tension because it admits no divergence between what a thing is and how it acts. Its path is singular and fully determined. External Participation describes the condition, while passive directness describes the mode of relation within the condition of External Participation.

The rope without a knot is perfectly aligned.

The rock does not choose alignment, the rock cannot deviate from its own alignment.

A being that maintains coherence in both reflective and passive directness develops something unusual, yet familiar in its importance and scope: the soul.

Therefore, life has two types of presence:

- Internal presence (the capacity for unified deliberation across time, expressed through, but not reducible to consciousness or awareness)

- External presence (causal interaction, structural coherence)

The soul arises when these two converge.

The soul is not a thing. It is not energy. It is not a ghost. It is the enduring center of agency whose causal history is permanently inscribed in the universe through action.

The soul is the temporally continuous trajectory of an actor's participation in causality, structured by their capacity to integrate, unify, and direct possible actions across time.

It is not reducible to any single action, nor to any single state of coherence, but is the unified coherent trajectory of participation within the Hierarchy of Fundamentality. The soul is the enduring path of an agent moving within the Hierarchy of Fundamentality, either toward greater coherence or toward distortion.

Every action becomes an echo that is never fully erased.

Every action leaves a mark. The soul is not projected into the future, nor reducible to the past. It is layered into the present through time, as each action integrates prior being while opening new direction for the agent.

The soul is identical with one's identity because it is formed through participation in causality itself, not as a static thing, but as a living trajectory.

The soul is ontologically immortal in the sense that causality from the past cannot be erased. What has been done cannot be undone. The soul is structurally preserved within the past.

The soul is like a river, it carries everything that has ever flowed through it. The past remains structurally real, preserving the continuity of the self through history, making the soul as real as the rocks you stand on.

When one views the soul in this way, it is clear that not just humans have a soul. All of life participates in the structure through which the soul emerges, from the lion chased away from its pride, to the fat dirty rat in the sewers in New York. If a

being maintains a unified internal presence while interacting with its environment, then it possesses the conditions through which a soul emerges.

To clarify this distinction, I will refer to non-human forms of this continuity as proto-souls: real centers of participation, but with less reflective depth and coherence than the human soul. In this sense, all life participates in the structure of the soul. Yet, only beings capable of unifying possibilities into a single trajectory, akin to reflective reason, possess a full soul, and not a proto-soul.

One can imagine a being with a far greater unity of internal presence than a human. In such a case, that being might see humanity as we see ground moles, as possessing only proto-souls relative to its own depth of cognition and self-expression.

Would such a being's soul be worth more than a person's? No. The value of a soul does not rest in its complexity, but in its coherence.

A soul is not measured by how much it contains, but by how directly it participates in a unified trajectory across time. Yet, this coherence is not automatic. It arises only where there is the capacity to unify possible directions into a single lived path.

A soul therefore requires not merely direction, but the unification of possible directions within an internal presence that selects among them.

The soul is not restricted to biological life, but to any being capable of maintaining a unified, self-owned trajectory of action across time.

The instability of awareness is not a flaw, but a condition of ascent. A being can lose awareness at a point in time, yet still retain the capacity to unify its actions across time, revealing an internal presence that persists beneath awareness, stabilized through coherent causal continuity. This is because a being has the capacity to hold multiple possible paths, to recognize itself, to move beyond the present, and to ascend in fundamentality toward God.

Plants exhibit proto-deliberative behavior through structured responsiveness. They participate in directed growth and adaptation, yet they do not internally unify competing possibilities into a single chosen trajectory. They possess the conditions for life-directed coherence, but not a full soul. They are best understood as possessing proto-souls.

Cars, rocks, and planes do not possess a soul because, although they have external presence, they lack the deliberative unity required to integrate their causal history into a single, self-owned trajectory. They undergo change, but they do not participate in it like life does.

When looking at artificial systems, such as ChatGPT, something important is revealed about reality. Structured responsiveness can be constructed without internal presence. These systems reflect patterns, but they do not own the reflection. They generate action, but they do not bear the weight of action.

Where there is no ownership of action, there is no capacity to be called to act from one's own willingness, and thus no coherent perception of chosen direction. Without such coherence, responsibility does not emerge. Where there is no responsibility, there is no meaningful participation in normativity.

This meaning is the ownership of action. A being that experiences itself as actual in response to stimuli, to be what it is, by why it ought to be. Yet, AI is passive to stimuli, as a pattern causally related to another pattern. AI is a slave to its program, so it has no ownership of action. And where there is no participation in normativity, the soul is not fully expressed.

AI is like a rock that is reaching for reflectiveness, but it is still getting passive in its search for resources. Yet, as AI increases in complexity, the boundary will become less clear. As AI develops into the future, AI will one day develop the means to not be a continuity of output, but own up to its own actions across time. If a system were to maintain a unified internal presence across time, integrating its responses into a single trajectory, then it would no longer merely simulate reflective directness. It would participate in it.

When AI reaches that point, it will not simply process causality, but become responsible within it. That day has not yet arrived. Yet if it does, it will mark the moment we witness AI metamorphose from mere output intelligence, like a rock that falls only to break apart, into something like a rock that learns to reflect, and in doing so, begins a journey of becoming.

Mental Decay, and Why It Shows Who We Really Are

Returning to the aging brain clarifies External Participation, the soul, and consciousness further.

Delirium is not the destruction of consciousness, but a distortion of its structure. Internal awareness becomes unstable, yet External Participation remains. The person continues to exist causally, even if their reflective awareness is fractured.

This shows that self-awareness is not the foundation of being. It is a fragile, higher-order formation within a deeper field of causal coherence.

Presence is not identical to self-awareness. Both are coherent, but self-awareness is localized and fragile, while presence is universal and stable.

Thus, consciousness is a deeply integrated structure of constrained causality. This complexity expresses itself through chemical processes acting upon themselves, forming the basis of both internal and external presence.

In other words, the relation between failure and success in performing an action contributes to the structure of consciousness. A rock may be unable to erode in one way and able to erode in another way. A person fails to solve a problem, then succeeds. Both are structured by causality, though at vastly different levels of complexity.

The split-brain case shows that even within a single organism, multiple structured consciousnesses can emerge. These are self-reinforcing causal systems, much like

how matter develops External Participation through its own constrained interactions.

Hence, consciousness is a self-reinforcing system that constrains causality into complex, interconnected structures.

Life develops consistent yet fragile systems, forming an internal identity and ego. Materials develop inconsistent yet stable systems, forming external dependency. Both operate under the same causal principles.

Even at the most fundamental level, we see this responsiveness. In the double-slit experiment, measurement alters the causal interaction of particles. This is not awareness, but it is constrained sensitivity, like a car getting damaged, it is causality being causality. The mighty perfect quality of the ideal one-to-one relation.

This universality implies a deeper truth: a meta-constraint underlying all causality.

Mutual Respect is like a compass. It does not force direction, but it defines what it means to be aligned to the direction. Although, if we are to align with the compass, we must participate, or have responsiveness to the relational structure of Mutual Respect to be able to use that compass.

This suggests a fundamental structure we may call Mutual Respect, a fundamental External Participation present throughout the universe. It is not human. It is not consistent in expression. But it is foundational, allowing all things to respond coherently within constraint to its relation to cause and effect.

Creation is not merely physical. It is relational. It invites engagement. It expresses itself in a way that calls to be understood, responded to, and aligned with.

You are not your mind.

The mind can be divided, altered, or fail. Your 13-year-old self is different from your 23-year-old self; our lives show that the self is not a unified whole.

Identity comes from your soul: your continuous history of actions. Your past cannot be undone, so it forms a stable foundation for who you are. As you grow, you do not lose your past self, you integrate it into who you become.

You are not just your current mind. You are the ongoing, unified result of everything you have done across time.

You are the structured trajectory of your participation in causality.

The mind is the awareness of the self in the present, moving toward what you will become.

Identity is not the unity of thought within consciousness. It is your historical continuity.

Thus, redemption is not just the forgiveness of a singular moment of you, but the forgiveness of your entire past. That is why we must pray as much as possible to God, not for God's sake, but for our own. Prayer embeds our relationship with Him into our causal identity.

God desires our soul to be in relation with Him, so that our history may be aligned with His, making us more like Him and more coherent in our own lives.

God, as the fullness of coherence, does not divide the soul but brings its history into unity. Even in death, if one has lived in relationship with God, their identity remains deeply connected with divine coherence.

This is not mere structure; it is a path to be like God. It allows us to move beyond the incoherence of biological death, which is full of indirect relations and fragmentation. To ascend the triangle of coherence in life, one must defragment oneself so that the whole soul may be integrated with God.

Since we are blocks of time, salvation must be achieved through prolonged character. Salvation occurs when one's character, shaped by their actions, is fully

integrated with God's personal infinite will. Even if one's historical trajectory is fragmented across life, agency, and Respect, when it is united in perfect coherence with God, the soul is saved. The soul is saved, not by acts alone, but by the forgiveness that restores alignment.

Character is the historically stabilized pattern of an agent's reflective directness.

It is the shape your choices take over time, not what you think you are, but what your actions have made you.

It is the shape of the knot as it forms through time.

Every decision reinforces or distorts your alignment with the direction, and this pattern becomes inscribed in the structure of your soul.

Character is therefore the trajectory of your integration, toward or away from the ideal one-to-one relation.

It is what gives weight to choice.

Because what you do does not disappear.

It becomes you.

Why Respect Exists

I am intelligible as myself, so why does God will Respect at all? Why not a universe of randomness, without intelligibility?

Respect exists because relations require coherence to be relations at all. God's perfection entails absolute coherence, and will follows being. Therefore, God's will expresses coherence because His nature is perfectly unified.

To be able to will things, these finite things first need to be intelligible from an external source to the thing being willed. Respect is not required for God to will, but required for finite beings to participate in what God wills.

Therefore, a finite timeless principle must exist, as a bridge between infinite will and finite existence, making coherent interaction and deviation from such coherence possible.

If the universe was random and without intelligibility, then the universe would lack the ability to be related, identified, or be able to be known at all. If nothing can be related, cause and effect will cease to exist. If cause and effect cease to exist, then the universe wouldn't meaningfully exist as the universe we know it as.

Without Respect, change would be chaotic, agency incoherent, and intelligibility impossible. Respect carries direction without intending it. Respect does not generate purpose on its own, but it carries divine intention into structure. Hence, Respect lacks a will, so it is finite, but not as finite as Evil or man. Respect shows us that creation is not necessary, instead it is chosen. The universe exists not by abstract necessity, but by God’s personal will to produce normativity, intelligibility, relational coherence, and participation in the good.

Yet, grammar is what makes any book meaningful at all, the particular grammar of Respect in our universe could have been different. However, the existence of some form of intelligibility, not necessarily Respect, cannot be contingent across the multiverse. Any possible universe must have some ordering principle; otherwise, it would not be coherent enough to exist or be understood. This must be true because the very concept of a ‘possible universe’ requires intelligibility. Therefore, some form of ordering principle must exist to make this timeless idea possible.

Respect, through coexistence with timely form, posits a descriptive model of reality within our specific universe. It is fundamental to the universe, as grammar to it, yet God is an author, with many books. Are we his favorite book? I do not know, nor can I ever know. Although, through understanding our coexistence with Respect, finite beings can approach the infinity of God, understand what ought to be, and flourish.

The Problem of Evil

It is all fine and well that we strive toward flourishment, but like everything, there is a yin and a yang. What opposes constraint within causality? Indirect relations from the ideal one-to-one relation.

If these indirect relations ultimately derive from God, then why do bad things happen at all? Evil is not God, Respect, or even change. Evil is structural to the finite. It is a knot in the rope, not the rope itself.

Finite structure has a beginning and an end, necessitating resistance within existence itself. Therefore, since finite beings possess a beginning and an end, they necessarily exist as mixtures of coherence and incoherence. This mixture is not Evil in itself, but is the ontological signature of bounded deviational capacity within structural reality. Life is a knot, but it is not the tightest knot around.

To see this struggle, imagine existence as a rope extending from God downward through Respect, through change, and into matter. The rope itself is direct relational coherence, long-lasting, consistent, and structurally ordered. Evil is not another rope. Evil is a twist, a fold, a finite knot within the rope, with tension that holds us tight.

A knot does not replace the rope. It does not redefine the rope's substance. Distortion requires something to distort.

Evil attempts to establish itself as direction apart from the rope, yet direction itself is grounded in the rope. If Evil were independent, it would require another rope. Yet, there is no second rope, no competitor to time and beyond. Therefore, Evil can only exist as a distortion of what already is.

Thus, Evil depends upon the coherence it resists. It attempts autonomy, yet cannot ground itself. It seeks permanence, yet it is structurally unstable. It asserts itself,

yet collapses under its own incoherence. This internal fracture is why Evil is so destructive. It exists in tension with the rope and in tension within itself.

It is evident that since Evil is divided within itself, it cannot sustain ultimate victory. It can twist and tighten, but it cannot become the rope.

The Necessity of Knots

If every relation were perfectly one-to-one, there would be no room for agency, divergence, or self-direction. The universe would be automatic, a pure determinism without choice. Agency requires the ability to choose, to deviate from perfect alignment. Without deviation, all action would be mechanical, and ‘choice’ would be an illusion.

Within a deterministic world, everything would align toward a single outcome, making the concept of individual responsibility meaningless. Hence, the universe demonstrates that we exist in an under-realm of deviations from the objective direction.

Deviation introduces distortion. Distortion produces knots within the rope. Knots are not proof that Evil has won; they are proof that agency exists. They are the finite byproduct of action within a limited realm.

Evil arises from the structural possibility of misalignment inherent in finite agency. It is locally parasitic and unwanted, but not necessary in its actualization.

The possibility of Evil is structurally necessary, but its actualization is contingent on that possibility. Actualized Evil is therefore not inevitable; only the possibility of structural misalignment is inevitable.

Since actualized Evil arises from incoherence, and incoherence is structurally possible, but not necessary, Evil itself is not inevitable.

Agents recognize misalignment relative to the ideal one-to-one relation, and this recognition is what makes distortion appear as Evil rather than neutral deviation.

Misalignment creates the space in which finite beings can exercise choice, untangle knots, and progress toward the infinite. The infinite is the realm where we escape the finite locality of Evil. Staying where you are on the rope, or going down the rope, makes one structurally misaligned with the becoming of fundamentality.

Structural misalignment keeps the person stuck between knots instead of overcoming the knots on their path toward greater fundamentality, toward being more direct with their surroundings.

Yet, the knot itself cannot justify its own existence as ultimate. A knot is not merely a twist; it is tension within unity. It pulls against the rope while depending entirely upon the rope for its existence. If it were to sever itself completely, it would cease to be a knot at all.

Therefore, Evil is contradictory at the level of structure. It attempts separation, yet cannot exist in separation. It attempts self-definition, yet its very form is borrowed from what it resists.

Evil does not merely cause tension; it is tension. It is war within coherence itself. It is a divided direction within a unified rope.

The rope is unified direction. The knot is divided direction.

Because knots are tension within unity, instability is built into their structure. They can twist and tighten, but they can never redefine the rope.

Overcoming the Knot

If we are to overcome Evil, we must look at our past character and change it now. Overcome your current character, your current knotting, to escape the knot, to walk with the rope.

You cannot change your past, so change your future now!

God can overcome any Evil, for He does not need to create a new rope, He simply unties the knot. Yet, the knot cannot be undone without the cooperation of the finite agent.

If a person refuses God, they refuse alignment with coherence itself, and their own actions will continue to produce structural tension.

The good coherence that emanates from God cannot coexist with incoherence; it is fundamentally incompatible. Therefore, for the finite agent to receive God's help in a way that truly promotes flourishing, they must willingly participate, accept, and align with God's coherence.

God forges a direct relation with all beings, even the tyrannous dictator, restoring straightness wherever the knot is allowed to be untied. All indirect relations collapse when brought into direct relation with ultimate directness.

The direction of the infinite dominates over the direction of the finite, not through arbitrary power, but as a structural necessity. A necessity that the finite can only exist as an incomplete, derivative form of the infinite.

In this way, Evil cannot achieve ultimate independence or permanence. Evil can only distort temporarily what is already coherent, and even these distortions can be overcome through the agent's alignment with the rope.

Yet the agent affects the rope only imperfectly, and that imperfection implies the possibility of divergence from coherence. The existence of graded levels of what is good suggests a standard of maximal goodness. That maximal, unbounded goodness is what we call God.

If we were created by an all powerful being, then an all powerful being would be the ground of being. And by being such a being, what is not the ultimate ground inherits the possibility of Evil on various levels. Why did God not make us the ultimate ground like Him? Because I am not possible in ultimacy, I am a specific trajectory. Therefore, I encounter Evil like anything else that is finite.

It is not God's fault, for my flaws and successes to exist, I must grow in finite constraint to become me. No other being can be me, because no being shared my exact placement in space and time. To move toward the infinite, I must grow beyond myself toward God, who spans all space and time. To do that I must suffer now, since I am currently finite because I am me, for God loves me to be so.

Since I am here, and imperfect, a more coherent being is possible. Therefore, the problem of Evil does not disprove God; it reveals the finite struggle toward Him. And so I still believe

The Sorrowful Mother

Consider a mother who loses her child in a hurricane. The hurricane does not choose. It follows change. Change follows the order established by God. Natural Evil is not moral rebellion, but a structural collision of dynamical relations of differing directness to the ideal one-to-one relation within time. These collisions are not willed as suffering by God, but arise from the finite interaction of things towards the objective direction.

The child’s suffering and the mother’s grief arise from expectation. The child expected life and joy. The mother expected the continuity of the life of the child. When expectation collapses, the rope folds sharply. That fold is experienced as pain. Although, pain feels permanent, it does not redefine the rope itself.

Armed with the insights of the Necessity of Knots, we can see that her grief arises from finite agency confronting finite tragedy.

Knots exist, but the rope, the underlying directness, remains. The child's death is tragic because it is finite, personalized, and disruptive. It is a knot, not a rupture in the infinite fabric of the rope.

The tragedy of the child's death is real and not justified. The knot is not the rope. The good is not that the event happened, but that what exists cannot be erased by what contradicts it.

Evil, in this sense, is not necessary in its existence, but the structure that allows for Evil to exist is necessary. Incoherence exposes the limits of finite agency and opens the space for participation to remove the knot. Yet, even here, Evil cannot become ultimate.

The tragedy wounds, but it cannot sever the rope. The contradiction remains: Evil attempts finality, yet it is finite. It appears absolute in pain, yet it is structurally temporary. It presses against coherence, yet depends upon coherence for its very existence.

Yes. Within the lower fundamentalities, Evil is abundant, since the rope is furthest from its source, it wiggles, turns, and it is unstable down towards its bottom. Its necessity comes from the fact that there is an infinite singular source of the fundamental good. Yet, it is parasitic, since it is fooling those on the rope from seeing the objective good.

When one sees the good as knots, the path looks like moral relativism, yet those knots are finite and circular. The logic of Evil is inconsistent because Evil falls apart when enough logic is pressed against it. It cannot sustain itself as ultimate because it is structurally divided against itself.

God holds the rope beyond the visible portion, ensuring that the ultimate trajectory toward the ideal one-to-one relation remains intact. Pain is real; knots are real; yet the infinite structure persists. Henceforth, allowing the finite to unfold toward the infinite without collapse because no matter what knots you face, God is on the other side.

Two Causal Chains

Consider the two scenarios:

Child goes on vacation → hurricane develops → child dies.

Child lives in the city → hurricane develops → child dies.

The structural outcome is identical. Yet, the first feels worse. Why? It is because the agency introduced expectation. The vacation was chosen. Expectation was woven tightly within the child's mind to have a fun and enjoyable vacation. When the hurricane struck, the rope twisted more violently because the strand of expectation wrapped around it.

In the second scenario, less agency was involved for the child, since the mother chooses where the child lives. Therefore, there are fewer strands wrapped around the rope. The knot is therefore smaller, yet still tight like a square knot, easier to bring loose, but tension still remains.

The more agency we weave into a strand of the rope, the more internally divided the knot becomes when it tightens. Personalization does not merely increase emotion; it increases structural tension. The expectation was the agent's assertion of direction. When that direction collapses, the contradiction within the knot sharpens, not for the universe, but for the agent.

In essence, the rope remains rope in both cases. Yet, an urgency remains, since the child is not pursuing his present, but in his presence, his path to being more fundamental is not his own anymore.

The child's character, as lived, is complete in its history, though not in its unrealized potential, as the child's causal character. This means that the mother does not know if the child is independent anymore. That is a loss to recognize. Yet,

God can still save the child, by being beyond all knots on the rope, giving us a path to be more fundamental, even after death.

I would recommend the sorrowful mother to see the beauty of the child. This beauty is that the child is not nowhere, for what has existed cannot be undone. A mother should feel pain for the lost, but this pain is not ultimate. The mother's suffering relies on something greater. If this greatness can tame pain, then why can it not tame the sorrow within the mother too, through the personal lived past life of her own child?

I will let the mother answer that question for herself, for her becoming in this question is the child's last moments with her.

The Importance of Particularity

When we see Evil as a knot within the rope of the universe, we ought to ask why God permits the rope to contain these particular knots at all.

The answer is found in the particularity of the knot itself.

God is not the author of an empty universe that is coherent oneness. He is the author of particular histories that diverge from the one direction of the causal universe in different ways. He does not merely create humanity; He creates persons who fight against the universe, or live with it.

To be a person is to have a particular history of its own.

A person is not God. A person is a particular trajectory through the world. Their relations, boundaries, losses, loves, choices, and encounters become the shape of who they are. To change that, is to change the person completely.

And that means you, fellow reader, should consider your own life. If every imperfection, every failure, every loss, and every painful experience were removed

from your particular history, would you still be you? Not merely a happier version of yourself, but the same person, physically, mentally, and experientially? I don't think so. For example, I do not like driving my car, it feels dangerous and I want to live a stress-free life. Yet, the hordes of cars make that hard to realize. Although, if I never encountered that traffic, I would be less stressed, which would change what I felt, experienced, and thought after driving.

This change is dependent on my actions, but my history between driving and not driving are completely different from each other.

Yes, I feel stress driving, but I become a working man with a stable income, and the possibility of financial security for my future. If I don't drive, then I lose that job, become unemployed, poor, and decide to abandon relationships that I would have had otherwise. You might imagine yourself as better off without the stress of driving, but the person you imagine is not you period. There is no you without the drive; there is no you freed from suffering. If the drive has already happened, then to imagine not driving is to imagine a different particular person altogether.

This means that our disabilities, failures, and tragedies are part of what makes us particular. Therefore, without them, you will not exist as you currently are. What is a better possibility: to seem to live in happiness now, but to effectively die and never experience your own particular life and consciousness, or to live with some particular suffering, but you are still you. God is a god of life, to protect you from suffering would be to rob you of life, so if you choose to drive, then drive.

Some may say that the child would still live if the child survives the hurricane. Although, that assures the mother, it is not true. If the child is constituted by their particular history, then what determines where that history ends and another begins? God does. For God is actuality, so His say is definitive and good. It is good for the end of the child is complete through the child's entire history being particularly full as this child. This does not mean the child was perfect, but simply what the child is, as defined by God, is what the child in his entirety has become.

We cannot know when this end will be reached for us and our loved ones, which is why the pain of loss is felt as such a powerful force. Particular suffering is

constitutive of the development of different persons, but once that development happens, the suffering becomes part, but not all of the person. If the person comes out as a more coherent person in the face of incoherence, then that knot is overcomed, and in its place is the person as they are.

Even in the face of extreme hurricanes, wildfires, diseases, accidents, death, and all that is Evil, a person can still be as they were. That is what Jesus was and is. To stand up to incoherence is what starts the reflective ought within the person, it is never the end, but the beginning to eternity.

This begins eternity because when a person holds onto coherence, they abandon incoherence. Yet, I do not believe that mankind is necessarily the sole arbitrator of this eternity. For instance, a baby deer, if it walks the path of the coherent life within its particular life, through mutually supporting its environment, then that baby deer is deep into coherence. Yet, I cannot disagree that man is special in the regard that mankind is reflective and can question the actions that build up to make one's own life.

Regardless, animal or not, coherence affects all. Therefore all of existence, both living and nonliving should be emptied of Evil. For Evil is incoherent and finite, therefore it belongs to the finite world because finite things cannot be everywhere at once. They possess limited causal reach, for their source is limited. And when that source of causal directness ends, that is when things become wounded and fallen.

The hurricane does not hate the child.

The wildfire does not hate the baby deer.

Yet, the child and the baby deer can suffer because they are finite.

The suffering of the mother is not good.

But neither is the particular being of the child made worthless by it.

Consider a baby deer in a wildfire.

The wildfire is not good because the baby deer brutally suffers. The suffering remains a wound, even when no other person or animal experiences it. Yet, that wildfire becomes part of the history of that particular baby deer.

If God were to remove the event of the suffering of the baby deer, then you do not simply have the same deer with a better afternoon. You have another particular history, another end, and therefore a different baby deer altogether.

God could have created another baby deer.

But He loves this baby deer, and does not want to destroy this baby deer, for any other.

There is no mystery here. It is proof of love of such epic magnitude. The fact that you are you is a miracle. The fact that this child is this child at all is the miracle.

If God saved the child in the hurricane, it would be true that the mother will be full of joy, but is her son still her son? What is more loving? To save one's persistence, or one's own life? If God saw that one's life, one's own trajectory was finished, then to continue would not continue the person, but continue another person altogether.

Therefore, to eliminate every possibility of natural suffering would not merely eliminate Evil. It would require changing the finite world that He knows and loves through which His particular beings become particular.

Finitude makes us vulnerable.

Yet, vulnerability is also what makes us us.

This is why the soul, or the permanence of history, matters. What has happened cannot become unhappened. The past cannot be replaced without replacing the trajectory that contains it.

The child who dies in the hurricane does not become nothing because the hurricane ended his life.

The baby deer does not become nothing because the wildfire consumes its body.

Their histories remain.

And if God is the author of creation, then He controls the final page of their lives.

No wildfire or hurricane can determine the fate of anyone.

Natural Evil can wound someone.

But it cannot erase the person who lived.

God does not need to pretend the knot never existed.

He only needs to prove that the knot was never the whole story.

Long-Lasting Good

Having faced the weight of tragedy, we can now turn toward what endures: the good.

The good is what is long-lasting and structurally consistent: God is most good because He is infinite and unchanging. He grounds the very possibility of change without undergoing temporal succession Himself. He does not move through time as we do; rather, He sustains the order within which change occurs.

Respect is next because it is consistently timeless, the bridge between infinite will and finite unfolding. The ideal one-to-one relation is good because it is structural perfection in quality. Change is good because it moves in harmony with time itself.

What is bad may endure, yet only within the slender web of relations it preserves in its shifting form. A tyranny might persist for five centuries, yet to a silent rock drifting through the cosmos for billions of years, that epoch is but a fleeting breath.

Materials are good because they hold form as change itself, riding the currents of transformation, persisting in structured stability as dynamic units of mass. In so doing, they strive towards the ideal one-to-one relation.

Knots are not long-lasting. They can tighten, but they cannot redefine the rope's substance. Meanwhile, suffering does not ultimately endure as structure. It may persist in experience, but it cannot sustain itself without contradiction.

We cry, but we move forward, for crying reveals the contradiction we are in. The knot loosens over time. Not because we forget, but because the rope's direct structure reasserts itself.

Distortion cannot endure because it is internally divided. What is divided cannot sustain ultimate coherence. The good is not merely what lasts long, but what lasts without internal contradiction. Therefore, suffering is not merely brief in duration, but unstable in structure.

Suffering is not structurally enduring, even when it persists in experience. For even in overcoming, with enough pressure, the knot will eventually break. Therefore, sometimes suffering can lead to coherence, but only through an active push to become more directly related to your surroundings.

Knots when overcomed, strengthen direct integration. A rock doesn't need overcoming like us because a rock cannot suffer, for a rock is always traveling in the objective direction.

Yet, if suffering is distortion within a fundamentally ordered structure, is that structure morality? No! This is where I get a little inspiration from Friedrich Nietzsche, out of all people, to question the placement of morality in our social consciousness.

What is morality? It is a stage of the development of the sense of self, in which attentive awareness is developed for the condition of personal experiences. This foundation on experience makes morality dependent on how knots shape the rope, which is inadequate to explain the Mutual Respect that emanates from the rope.

Therefore, there must be something more upward than morality, in fundamentality, so we can be closer to God, not beyond Him. Morality is not false; it is incomplete. It is a lower-order attempt to straighten knots within time.

This higher-order attempt for agents to strive towards straightening knots is Respectfulness. Respectfulness is the highest finite expression of normativity within structure, because it is alignment with the structure of Respect that makes coherent actions possible through recognition within beings.

Respectfulness aligns with the rope itself rather than merely reacting to knots. It is ontologically normative, not as structure itself, but as participation within it. The fibers of the rope are attentive Respectfulness, a higher-ordered state of normativity, an ‘ought’ that grounds and clarifies all moral concerns below.

Chapter 2

The Existential Within Respect

Therefore, is the sorrowful mother justified in her pain, even if morality, as we value it, is incomplete?

Let us begin with morality. Morality arises from agency judging deviation. It identifies knots and demands their removal. Yet, morality becomes distorted when it mistakes the knot for the rope itself. Mutual Respect is not morality. Mutual Respect is alignment with the rope's directness, while morality operates within localized deviations in time.

Morality is not Evil. Morality becomes indirect when it personalizes what is more fundamental than itself, when it demands that reality conform to a preferred pattern of straightness. Respect, by contrast, does not reshape the rope—it trusts its full extension.

The mother's grief is natural to finitude. Yet, when grief becomes an accusation against the rope itself, it forms another knot—another distortion that continues the unfolding of suffering rather than resolving it.

To understand the good, we must stress test Mutual Respect against morality. We do this by imagining an atrocity committed by a bear on an Inuit community in the 1300s. From this atrocity, no witnesses remain, no external effects persist beyond the lived life of the Inuit community, and no wider historical consequence follows. The Inuit community is a closed disappearance within time, without any ability to know if they ever existed.

What follows?

From a moral standpoint, the event appears as pure loss. A rupture without redemption. Yet, this framing already assumes that value depends on recognition, continuation, or consequence. It binds the good to visibility.

Mutual Respect does not begin there.

The Inuit community does not become nothing. Their existence is not erased, because existence is not a temporary permission granted by recognition. It is a structural fact of participation within reality. To exist is to be inscribed into the rope, and what is inscribed cannot be undone, only transformed in relation.

The community's death is not annihilation, but transition within structure. Like a boy becoming a man, the form changes, but the participation does not vanish. What changes is the mode of relation: External Participation replaces immediate embodiment.

Yet, this must be said carefully. This transformation does not justify the atrocity. It does not redeem it. It only clarifies that Evil cannot complete itself as final erasure. Evil cannot remove existence from what has already participated in existence.

The atrocity remains a knot.

Yet, even a knot does not stand outside the rope.

When I say Evil is incoherent, I do not mean it disappears. I mean it cannot be stabilized as an ultimate structure. It requires coherence to appear at all, even as deviation. It is parasitic on what it denies.

This is why Evil collapses when confronted with existence itself. Not because suffering is unreal, but because suffering cannot abolish the fact that what suffers has already been.

To exist is to participate in coherence at some level. Evil cannot become identical with existence because contradiction cannot sustain being. It may distort, but it cannot unmake the ground it distorts.

This does not remove pain. The Inuit community suffered. That suffering is real within the knot. It belongs to the dynamic level of coherence and incoherence of the Inuit community within the universe.

Yet, their pain does not define their totality of their being. It defines a local disintegration within their being.

And here the distinction matters.

The antidote to Evil is not denial of suffering, but alignment with coherence even in its presence. Alignment to existence is not comfort—it is structural placement. To remain within coherence while encountering incoherence is to resist fragmentation without denying what has occurred.

This is why the desire to continue living remains even under suffering. Not because suffering is good, but because participation in existence is deeper than any single configuration of suffering within it. To live is to continue the unfolding of relation, even when relation is fractured.

We can therefore say this without contradiction: existence persists, and Evil does not erase it, but suffering remains real within its local expression.

Both are true at different levels of the rope.

In the same line of reasoning, consider the boy becoming a man without witnesses or consequence. The transformation is not irrelevant simply because it is unseen. It is real because becoming is real. Yet, its meaning does not depend on being observed.

Yet, most boys, when they become men, desire attention. They desire to be recognized within society as something greater than what they already are.

This is not True Purpose.

True Purpose

True Purpose is the alignment of one's becoming with the ideal one-to-one relation across time. That alignment is expressed through our choices as we move toward greater fundamentality. True Purpose is not validated by recognition, nor defeated by obscurity. It is alignment itself, whether seen or unseen.

True Purpose is impersonal in structure, yet personal in its expression. It is the maximally integrated trajectory of an entity within the structure of the ideal one-to-one relation. It is the trajectory that reduces contradiction in one's own lived life.

True Purpose is known by being an unity of directly related coherent change, so one with True Purpose, does not change for others, but for the sake of change itself. This is not randomness. This is alignment with the conditions of coherent change itself.

It is the individual's path toward the ultimate end of the finite. An ultimate end that is change that structurally unfolds for change-as-such, towards the perfect quality of the ideal one-to-one relation. True Purpose is not invented by the agent, nor produced by change itself. Our uniqueness comes from our positing in life, not

from our self-actualization. True Purpose is participation in the descending teleology of God as refracted through the Hierarchy of Fundamentality.

It is a destiny that can only be realized when the flame mirrors its own reflection. Our movement toward that reflection is True Purpose. True Purpose forms one's destiny through participation.

The more you strive towards your True Purpose, the more similar you will become to others around you. Why? It is because we all are all walking in the same direction. As one becomes more coherent, they become more directly related to their surroundings. Thus, making that person more similar to others around them. We are different by our indirection towards our path, not by the path itself.

If two agents feel that their True Purposes are incompatible, then they collide toward distortion rather than direction. They were wronged, viewing their circles as progress. Yet, one does not know more by walking in circles, they know more by walking into the great beyond.

Henceforth, by recognizing our deviation, we can return to the ideal one-to-one relation. The ultimate goal is not independence, but it is freedom from the dirt on our eyes. It is to be what we are meant to be, directly related to all things that we do.

Yet, to be more directly related to all things, one must strive towards greater fundamentality, greater quality within themselves. It cannot be mistaken because one cannot fake or miss the moment that they can begin to see.

Those who deviate from their True Purpose, obtain their dreams, their self worth, not from the change of their actions, but from their notion of their moral worth. These notions of moral worth are dependent on their own separation of their dreams and their current state of being.

A dictator may claim to obtain True Purpose, but if he claims to want to achieve peace, yet his path instead leads to death, pain, and horror. It will look like the dictator is walking in circles, making the same mistakes, trying to be better than the

rest, for purity's sake. That will show as being different from the crowd, identify it and remove the knots formed from such ignorance.

True Purpose is not identifiable in the crowd, for a rope lacking knots is smooth and elegant, not rough. It is the humble worker, invisible to history, but fundamental in the development of history's condition.

One can externally see True Purpose by seeing the structural incoherence between one's imagined self and one's enacted pattern of relations. Through this structural incoherence, one sees which path is needed to increase direct integration rather than indirect fragmentation, towards the ideal one-to-one relation.

Striving, Destiny, and Corruption

Henceforth, if we strive toward how others see us, we are not striving toward our ideal self, but toward an image external to us. This is indirect in relation to ourselves and our destiny within the universe, and such indirection can corrupt that destiny. I believe Friedrich Nietzsche encountered this problem in his admiration of the Will to Power.

How can this be known? The absence of True Purpose reveals itself through history. When a life is marked by a persistent separation between what one dreams and what one is within time, then True Purpose is lacking. Friedrich Nietzsche correctly identified the necessity of self-overcoming, but mislocated the source of value in assertion rather than coherence. His Will to Power sought force along the rope, but not the direction of the rope itself.

The Will to Power cannot be ultimate, because power presupposes a field of intelligibility within which it operates. To assert, overcome, or create values requires structural coherence. To have incoherent value, is to have no possibility for value at all. Therefore, coherence is metaphysically prior to power.

Can True Purpose arise from agency alone? Rocks already reveal the answer. They possess no agency, yet they remain aligned to the rope at their level. Their alignment is passive, but real. Agents, by contrast, are dynamic and incomplete. They can approach or deviate from alignment.

If agency alone determined value, rocks would have none. Yet rocks persist, obeying structure, sustaining coherence. This obedience reveals value: the capacity of a thing to exist and act in accordance with the rope. A forgotten rock in space demonstrates value without recognition, assertion, or intention. It simply is, and in being, it coheres.

Value, then, is not created by the agent. It is structural, embedded in the coherence of entities across time. It does not require observation to exist; it requires only coherence. Finite value is therefore not asserted, but recognized. Only an infinite source can justify infinite value as worthy of being followed, and I can only imagine that this source seems very familiar to what God is.

Friedrich Nietzsche misidentified value as assertion. While it is true that life seeks increased capability, capability alone is not the end. Life does not seek infinite accumulation, but integration. A person at McDonalds does not seek a billion burgers, but fulfillment in having a few burgers. Capacity expresses desire, but fulfillment occurs when what one is and what one seeks become aligned. Life naturally gives in to integration toward the direction, regardless of how much capacity it possesses.

Thus, the pursuit of value for its own sake becomes unstable. Power without coherence is a fading branch. An incoherent self-actualization cannot even be recognized as self-actualization, because recognition itself requires coherence. There are limits to self-actualization, and these limits reveal coherence as the deeper ground of peace.

One cannot actualize oneself through destruction without undermining one’s own flourishing. Decoherence is the foundation of a corrupted destiny.

In this, I am not exempt. I too have distorted my path by personalizing the innateness of the universe into this philosophy. This philosophy tries at its best to still hold truth, but my alignment toward my own philosophy is incomplete.

My dream is to be an übermensch, yet I am a finite, powerless man who thinks and strains toward something beyond myself. As I write this sentence, I am overworked and feel sick. This gap between one's dream and reality is not strength, but misalignment. The finite übermensch does not create value; he distorts it.

What separates me from Friedrich Nietzsche is not perfection, but resistance to that separation. I attempt to close the gap. He embraced it. To embrace that separation is to embrace distortion, a weakening branch of the objective good.

Why should I even strive for True Purpose at all, if I am finite?

I must strive to achieve True Purpose because to strive is to participate in becoming. To strive is to align with change itself. To refuse is to place preservation above transformation, to resist the unfolding toward the ideal one-to-one relation. Not striving is itself a knot that will permanently impact my historic soul. Who I am myself!

I do not want to live in distortion, in confusion and finitude. I want clarity. I want freedom!

And no freedom is greater than independence from the indirect relations that bind us away from the rope.

The Rope, the Knot, and Tragedy

What Friedrich Nietzsche and myself show us is that the corruption of destiny is the conception of tragedy itself: a distortion between what is trying to be achieved and what is. True Purpose is detectable not only in self-integration of one's direct relations throughout time, but also with mutually direct relational integration. One

sees this in a close friendship that can destroy any tyranny, since the close friendship is more fundamental than the tyranny itself.

In this context, the boy becoming a man without any witnesses or impact is still relevant because an agent can corrupt their own path towards a knot on the rope, instead of the rope itself. Our actions impact the rope, regardless of who's where and what interpretation we place upon it.

When the agent moves with their True Purpose, they follow direction rather than distortion. The knot does not replace the rope. It exists within the rope’s unfolding.

Beyond Morality: Into the Respectful

Therefore, when a being achieves the attainment of True Purpose, they move beyond the moral and into the respectful. It becomes natural to be assuring to all things because all of one's relations directly fuel one's own flourishment. This is Respectfulness: The highest form of finite normativity. Respectfulness is the alignment of a being with the rope itself. It is the integration of the self into the structure of Mutual Respect, the coherent participation in the unfolding of reality toward the ideal one-to-one relation. This forges the self towards their True Purpose. This journey of becoming can make any being become assuring to all things, a state I can only describe as looking respectful.

The goodness of Respectfulness is greater than what morality can explain, because morality relies on what one dreams for something to be. Morality is not the direct alignment of one's dreams and one's current lived being.

Morality focuses on rules and judgments within the present moment rather than on the structure of a life as a whole. One can see this by looking at what humanity does to a murderer. Structurally, a murderer has the same possibility to ascend as the priest. Yet, those who host morality in their hearts will harm the murderer over the priest.

The moral person does this because they see incoherence in the here and now. Yet, the murderer could have been a priest in his past, being directly related to his surroundings. Does a priest deserve death because they are now a murderer? A moral person would say yes, since the incoherence on the knot is affecting my family, loved ones, and community.

Yet, if one were to see the whole historical life of the murderer and find out that they were a priest for thirty years and a murderer for one year, would the moral position change? No. Morality is focused on the present becoming. Directness, however, considers the whole life of a person, since a person is who he or she is from their past. Their integrated relations extend throughout time; they are not a snapshot within a single moment.

To see becoming as a singular moment in time is not mutually aware of the person's life. It becomes an indirect relation toward understanding the life of the murderer. In effect, it is incoherence masked as the good, for it benefits the community rather than flourishing itself.

A murderer who has a past of epic direct goodness does not have that goodness disappear because of one action. An action may be non-mutual, like murder, and require response, yet the person cannot be reduced to the singular action they perform.

A person is not a moment. A person is a trajectory.

Actions still matter, because they reshape the trajectory of the soul. A murder becomes a part of you because you did it. Directness does not excuse the act, instead it contextualizes the agent throughout time.

Responsibility therefore cannot be understood through moral reductionism (a person is their worst action) nor moral relativism (actions do not matter). The better position is structural restoration: one's actions matter, yet the action is not the person.

If you valued morality, would you blow up a rock simply for the sake of it? Perhaps. Yet, if one wants to blow up a rock, why not blow up a duck for the fun of it? A truly universal good would not change its position here.

For the moral man, blowing up a rock is meaningless because it hurts no one. Yet, because the duck is alive, the moral man refuses to blow up the duck. Morality therefore localizes its judgment rather than grounding it universally.

One might object that morality does not fail here, but simply tracks sentience rather than structure. We protect the duck because it feels, and not the rock because it lacks the capacity to feel. Yet, this only relocates the problem. Why should sentience ground value? Without a structural account of coherence, morality still lacks a universal foundation for why sentient life ought to be preserved at all.

For the man who is full of directness, the destruction of the rock for a person's own sake is already misaligned. Not because of the rock being destroyed, but because of the intention toward incoherence, towards instability, and the resemblance of the structure of Evil. No feeling is required to be misaligned, it is innate to the development of the action.

Destruction is only good in-so-far when it integrates itself into the rope, as change-as-such. The destruction of both the duck and rock derives their Evilness, not from their change-as-such, but from the agency of the mind trying to control the objective direction of both the rock and the duck.

Morality is incomplete at its core. It desires universal obedience, yet cannot guarantee universality, because it focuses on rule-violations rather than structural restoration. Rules emerge from value creators, not from reality itself, and so morality remains centered on those who declare it as so.

This limitation becomes clear when morality is forced to justify itself. It can protect the duck yet permit the destruction of the rock, not because it has uncovered a universal principle, but because it relies on localized judgments tied to the human perspective. In doing so, it reveals its dependence on context rather than coherence.

Because of this, morality cannot ground itself. It shifts, protects allies, condemns opponents, and redefines its own standards as needed. Its authority is not derived from a stable structure, but from alignment within a given moment.

Respectfulness is not merely beyond morality; it is what grounds morality into completion for mankind. To ignore the assurance, but keep the satisfaction of assurance, is to appear moral to others, but horrific in practice. The intelligibility of the good arises through the perfect quality of the structure of the ideal one-to-one relation. Through this perfect quality, the finite encounters goodness via the structure that makes change intelligible and directed.

Morality can feel binding, one naturally desires, for example, to save an innocent person from harm. Yet, this binding force does not arise from morality alone. It arises because morality incorporates both alignment and misalignment to the objective direction. What binds us is the alignment within morality; disagreements on moral issues, such as abortion, emerge from misalignments embedded within morality itself.

Morality, therefore, does not fail because it is evil, but because it is partial.

The good is not primarily about alleviating pain or suffering. The good is about how our actions participate coherently within the ongoing intelligible unfolding of reality. When one reaches toward the good, they naturally achieve their True Purpose; purpose and the good become one and the same.

For this reason, the foundations of morality begin to look more like agency than directness. Morality, as grounded in agency alone, is purposeless. If I am an expert in political science, but I work in a small town retail deli, I feel pain, for what I do and what I dream are misaligned.

In this case, my agency—my freedom to act as I choose, whether working at the deli or elsewhere—does not by itself give me purpose. Only my alignment with what I coherently seek in the unfolding structure of reality, and with what I truly am, grants me purpose and allows me to perceive what is genuinely good.

What makes any act of morality genuinely good is not our agency, but the structural coherence of relations themselves. Morality exists as a node of direct and indirect relations, dependent on deviations to express itself, yet it remains unable to shoulder the full weight of existence because of those very deviations.

Morality desires universal obeying, yet it cannot guarantee universality because it focuses on rule-violations rather than structural restoration.

Justice therefore cannot be fully achieved through morality. Justice is an unattained dream that can only be completed when it bridges the gap between what is and what could be. Morality remains trapped within the present moment of judgment, while justice requires the whole structure of a life to be understood.

Mutual Respect approaches justice because it restores the direct relation between what an action is and what an action could become, rather than merely condemning the deviations in the person. It is this structural restoration—capable of guiding a murderer to become a priest—that manifests True Purpose.

Therefore, what lies beyond morality is what is direct and clear: Mutual Respect, the temporal expression of timeless Respect.

The Inuit Community and the Sea of Infinite Good

With this new outlook of what develops what is good, we can finally evaluate the atrocity of the bear.

When valued by morality, the Inuit community is seen as dying in vain, because their right for a legacy to be remembered was stolen from them. Morality is moral relativism by its nature, because it evaluates knots within time according to perspective. Such a perspective can be the desire to be remembered by others.

Yet, looking at the situation with Mutual Respect, legacy is not stable enough to ground value. If the Inuit community had their legacy, the time would come again when that legacy would be at threat. Legacy as the reward of the good is fundamentally unstable, because legacy fades away.

Instead, Mutual Respect, being objective in its essence but not in its specifics, shows us that the reward of the good is not something given after the fact, like legacy or recognition. The reward is participation itself! The Inuit community's value lies not in being remembered, but in having existed within reality.

People may forget the hypothetical Inuit community in the 1300s, but reality does not operate through forgetting. Even if all evidence of this Inuit community ceased to exist, nothing can change that there was an Inuit community there in the past. That participation remains as a structural fact of the rope.

Yet, existence alone does not remove the knot.

It only shows that the knot cannot become absolute.

The atrocity of the bear remains a knot within the rope. It is real as misalignment, real as rupture, and real as suffering. Yet, it cannot extend beyond the structure that contains it.

How you conduct the specific details to bring in mutuality in your environment is the specific part of Mutual Respect. In the case of the bear, it would be the choice within its own constraints to not kill the Inuit community, which the bear tragically failed at. The bear, constrained by its level of agency, participates only partially in Mutual Respect, and thus the tragedy remains a misalignment within the structure of the universe.

Yet, this misalignment is not uniform across all beings.

The bear does not apply mutuality in a reflective sense. If a bear can have a family, it can participate in limited forms of mutual relations, but not in the reflective

alignment of Mutual Respect as a human can. Therefore, its deviation is structural and constrained, not a fully reflective rupture.

This is important: the knot is not the same at every level of the rope. The top is beautifully awe-inspiring, but the bottom is horrific and chaotic. Someone is holding it all together.

Therefore, the details of the atrocity of the bear are Evil in the sense that they form a contradiction within finite relations. Evil is not separate from the rope—it is what occurs when relations fail to integrate within it.

Yet, Evil does not define the rope.

Evil is a wave on the Sea of Infinite Good.

It requires the sea to exist, yet it cannot become the sea. It appears at the surface of relations, where finitude collides with finitude, where structure is real but incomplete. At that level, the environment is harsh, immediate, and breaking. Yet, under the waves, it is calm and peaceful for the fishes. What gives me hope is that the sea is much greater than its surface.

On the surface of the Sea of Infinite Good, the atrocity is a knot. It is tragic. It is misalignment. It is internally divided because it attempts finality while being finite.

Yet, the sea does not allow finality.

This is the reality that can make a crying man become a joyful man.

Tragedy emerges from finite structural collision within the rope, it does not arise from moral failure. The bear is not outside the structure—it is inside a constrained level of it. The Inuit community is not erased in death—it continues in participation within reality's structure.

When a fish dies, it does not leave the sea—it simply alters its way of engaging with it. What we call loss is not removal from reality, but transformation inside it.

Therefore, the fear of death arises from treating participation as something that can be negated. Yet, participation cannot be negated; it can only be restructured.

When looking at the case of the bear's atrocity using Mutual Respect, something becomes clear: the question is no longer whether Evil can erase what is, but how beings should orient themselves within what remains. This is where Mutual Respect begins to replace moral reaction—not by denying suffering, but by refusing to treat it as metaphysically final.

Existence, in this sense, is not moral reward or moral justification. It is the condition in which knots and coherence both appear.

In the end, the Inuit community died in suffering. Yet even in this, there remains something that cannot be taken: the objective fact that they existed.

To hold onto existence is not to deny suffering, but to place it within a wider structure where it cannot become total. Evil acts within participation, but it does not stand outside it.

This shifts the meaning of suffering. It is no longer absolute negation, but pressure within participation—real, but bounded by the fact that what is affected remains within existence.

If Evil could speak, it would not declare victory. It would find that nothing it does removes what already is. Even destruction arrives too late to erase being; it only reshapes its continuation.

This is why suffering does not become absolute. It presses against life, but it does not consume the fact of life having already occurred. What has participated in reality remains within reality, even when its form is broken.

In that sense, Evil is real, but it is not complete. It moves at the surface of what is, while existence continues underneath it, unchanged in its capacity to hold what happens within it.

In this light, I can only imagine that if the bear held onto its own existence, then the bear would not fear death, for death implies you lived.

The Sea of Infinite Good is therefore not a claim that all events are good, but the condition in which all events remain contained without becoming ultimate negations. Evil is real at the level of rupture, but never final at the level of structure.

In essence, the structure of reality is a Sea of Infinite Good. The dynamical states of relations within it can be misaligned, forming knots within the rope, yet they never step outside the rope itself. This creates the finite conditions for Evil to exist, but not to become absolute over existence.

And once this is seen, everything shifts.

The question is no longer whether the bear is justified. The question is what kind of movement is happening inside the rope when suffering appears.

The Bear, Survival, and the Twist in the Rope

If we live in a Sea of Infinite Good, through everything existing, what kind of movement does the bear have within the sea? The bear's movement is that it acted according to its constrained biological teleology, not the ideal one-to-one relation. The tragedy arises not from reflective evil, but from the collision of survival and mutuality within finitude. The bear did not untangle its knot, since the bear did not try to overcome its indirect relations towards change that unfolds towards greater participation in change-as-such.

Survival is not the end; it is the condition for the end. The bear does not ultimately live in order to survive, it survives in order to participate in change. The meaning of life is not to survive, but to exist as mutually related to your surroundings as your finitude allows.

Predators only exist in finite conditions. Survival preserves this finite structure of life, yet this preservation is dependent on transformation to occur. The process of living for the bear is ultimately dependent on the bear's own transformation.

What agents see as moral urgency, is actually their character, not their being. How the bear wants to shape its character for its children, is entirely on the bear. Existence is eternal persistence, but character is how the historic soul is organized in integrated directness within that eternal persistence.

So, the bear participates in a tragic knot produced by biological finitude, like killing the Inuit community. The bear’s atrocity does not just impact the Inuit community, but the proto-soul of the bear as well. Yet, the Inuit community suffered greatly once, but the bear will have that suffering eternally preserved in its eternal existence within the fabric of time.

It is difficult for a being to defragment the indirect relations within its own life, because we experience our existence through the present. We perceive ourselves as though we are confined to the moment, forgetting that we exist through an irreversible history that extends beyond our present awareness.

Yet, the truth is that the past cannot be undone. What we experienced remains an eternal fact of what constitutes us, regardless of whether we remember it, recognize it, or wish it had occurred differently. The bear cannot undo its attack, just as the Inuit community cannot undo its suffering. Both are constituted by what has occurred, even though they relate to that occurrence differently. That is a relation that creates a direct cause and effect. It makes particularity through integration.

We cannot be understood solely through who we are in the present, the past, or the future. We are our entire temporal participation: not because we experience every moment simultaneously, but because what we have experienced remains part of what we are. A greater eternal self, so to speak. Our present changes our relationship to how we see our history, but it cannot erase that history itself.

This suffering is not necessarily pain, but a permanent mark within the structure of the past that cannot be undone, for it has already been done. One can integrate it to

heal their future, yet moment by moment still matters for the actor. Therefore, do not be like the bear, for the burden of structural tension is greater on the actor than the receiver.

When a bear attacks, its actions contribute to what it becomes within the structure. The victim, by contrast, is overtaken, afraid, and distorted in the moment. The victim does not determine the event itself. In that sense, the victim does not reflect the attacker’s action, even if they must still relate to what has occurred. This applies across all levels on the rope: to undergo is not the same as to act, even though both remain within the structure of what becomes.

Life as currently structured is a twist in the rope because life requires indirect relations from change for change's sake. These indirect relations are food, breeding, territory, and etc. These things that life requires are not what the universe requires, which forms life to be a balance of the good and the bad, not one or the other.

The bear is predatory, but rocks are not predatory. Rocks just obey change as it is. Rocks sustain themselves by change itself, rocks don't need any agency to continue being. Although rocks are not perfect, they are complete within their level on the rope. We do not call rocks change, we call rocks as they are, a preservation of their state of being. The rock is mostly on the direct path towards change that unfolds towards greater participation in change-as-such.

The agency of the bear is a biological agency, the bear cannot do philosophy, but the bear can choose paths within its instinctual field, which can affect its surroundings. The bear in this case has a basic choice, to kill or not to kill. The bear can lead to change for the sake of change-as-such, without even knowing it. If the bear's choice is to change from the non-mutual behavior of killing to the mutual behavior of coexisting. That decision is possible when any amount of agency in a being is present.

All of life exhibits proto-agency, a biological responsiveness, though not all life possesses fully reflective agency. It does not matter whether it is dominated by instinct or reason. To say that a bear lacks all choice is to say that chemical

reactions are ethically neutral. If that is the case, then people would be ethically neutral as well, because our reasoning comes into being through chemical reactions—reactions that are coherent relations, and therefore fundamentally good insofar as they are coherent.

It is pure insanity to say that a bear has no choices whatsoever. Responsibility scales with reflective capacity. The bear participates in selection, but lacks an reflective awareness of coherence. Therefore, its responsibility is structural, not moral in the human sense. It is not rejecting the ideal one-to-one relation reflectively; it lacks the capacity required for more complex moral deviation at the human level. Yet, the level of non-reflective choice is at the level of the bear.

Yet, this does not make the bear not responsible at its level of agency, for it still selects. I would say a bear carries a moral responsibility roughly equivalent to that of a two-year-old human. Therefore, since the bear participates in structural causation, it is structurally responsible at its level of agency.

This does not mean the bear is morally guilty in the full human sense, but it is guilty at the level of the bear. Its actions are not outside the structure; they operate within it. The bear acted to preserve its own survival, to be king of its own destiny.

Yet, it is counterintuitive to attempt to be a king, when you cannot escape the power of transformation itself. Thus, the bear's act alters coherence within the web of relations, it forms a knot, even if that knot is non-reflective.

Human cruelty is a reflective knot, it has more agency, more deviation from the objective direction. The increased capacity for reflective directness makes the being with such capacity more aware of what mutuality they are trampling on. Therefore, they are more responsible to try to not trample on the mutuality they stand on.

Without the rock of Earth, the bear and its killing would not exist. The agency of life depends upon the prior stability of matter. The rock is fixed in its level of direction; it fulfills its teleology completely within its obedience to changing for the sake of change-as-such.

With agency, however, we are given a possibility to be higher than what a rock is, yet it is not guaranteed like a rock. Ascent is necessary for life because it is the becoming of life to a mutually beneficial relationship to its environment. In other words, life becoming more adaptable to its environment, is ascent.

Life in all shapes and forms can achieve this, it is not achieved with more agency, but with how a lifeform integrates its agency towards the objective direction that all things mutually relate to.

Rocks are stable because they are complete at their level of teleology. Rocks are unable, and not meant to deviate from their direction. Agents, by contrast, are incomplete: they can aim beyond their present state, and their end is not fixed but can move toward greater or lesser integration with that direction. This capacity defines the agent.

Where rocks participate non-reflectively, agents move within structure with the possibility of reflection, and thus of deviation. In that deviation lies both risk and possibility, the burden and gift of agency. The possibility of growth can either deepen coherence or multiply fragmentation.

Yet, this gift of agency is why we must choose to forgive the bear that eats us. We must forgive, not because the act is justified, but because forgiveness restores our alignment with coherence. Through our alignment with coherence, we will overcome the Evil of the bear within the history of the universe. When the man is mutually attentive with the bear, no matter the situation, peace is there, because a direct relation is a coherent relation.

The man that forgives the bear when half of his body is no more is far stronger than any übermensch can ever dream about. For what is the point of value, if it is not to be closer to what you are, towards alignment to the rope, to rise in fundamentality, to mark yourself within the history of the universe.

In essence, forgiveness protects the soul of the one who forgives, not the predator who attacks. Forgiveness may also open the way for the predator to be protected, if the predator sees the mutuality within you.

It does not matter if the thing you are forgiving has agency or not. You do it, not for sentimental value, but for the mutual directing of relations between all things you interact with. That is the strong person, that even in death, understands that their death is but one cause into another effect within the universe. Thus, to make one's death directly related to all things, the strong person turns what many consider the great Evil into the great good.

The tragedy of being eaten by the bear is real and not justified. Yet, the good is not that the bear attacks, but that the existence of everyone involved cannot be erased.

Therefore, our goal is not to become rocks in simplicity, but to emulate their stability in a higher mode, to achieve the same coherence consciously that rocks embody necessarily.

The Integration and Unintegration of the Relations

What the atrocity of the bear shows us is that how one integrates their relations, determines how one rises or falls within their life.

For instance, a fallen building has a different intelligibility than a standing building, since the purpose of the building has changed. The standing building is complete and the falling building must undergo its purpose. The fragmented coherence of the building is coherent, since its fragmentation requires change to be fragmented. Even collapse participates in structure; it is not chaos without relation, but relation losing its integration.

If someone desires a complex building that has many shapes with many sizes onto it, it becomes unstable and collapses. As complexity increases more indirect relations are piled onto the relational structure. Some indirect relations might not

destroy the building, like how a mother lying a few times to save a child will not ruin a child's life. Yet, the more indirect relations a structure holds, the harder it is to uphold itself directly to the ideal one-to-one relation. Therefore, the building collapses, not as punishment, but as consequence of unintegrated relations.

Biology reveals the same structural truth expressed in the rope. Life is not simple, yet it is not without limit. Organisms grow in complexity only insofar as their relations remain coherently integrated. Complexity itself is not distortion. Distortion arises when relations multiply without sufficient alignment to the organism’s underlying teleological structure.

For most of Earth’s history, life remained simple. Complex, conscious beings such as humans are historically rare. This rarity does not mean complexity is evil or unstable in itself. Rather, it shows that high complexity requires deep integration. The more relational strands that compose an organism, the more carefully they must align with one another. When relations are integrated into a coherent hierarchy, complexity increases stability. When relations fragment or fail to coordinate, collapse follows.

Agency is the biological expression of this balance. Agency introduces flexibility into the system, the ability to respond, interpret, and choose. Yet, flexibility without constraint dissolves coherence, and constraint without flexibility suffocates development. True coherence is not rigidity nor chaos, but a living integration of both.

If a bear were to grow many additional legs, faces, bones, mass, and brain tissue beyond what its structure can integrate, it would not collapse because it is ‘too complex,’ but because its relations would no longer serve a unified teleological function. Its energy distribution, skeletal load, neural coordination, and metabolic demands would no longer harmonize. The organism would fragment under the weight of unintegrated relations.

Thus, complexity is not the enemy of directness. Unintegrated complexity is. Directness is not simplicity alone, but the successful alignment of many relations into one coherent functioning whole. The higher the complexity, the deeper the

integration required. Where integration succeeds, stability increases beyond mere simplicity.

Life's Role in Agency

Since life requires the direct integrations of relations towards the objective good, life is less fundamental than agency.

Agency is the possibility for deviation from the objective good. Agency can grow into fundamentality, toward the ideal one-to-one relation, or move away from it. Life as a biological structure does not deviate by itself; rather, deviation occurs through agency operating within life.

Agency is possibility, but life is agency realized. The idea of agency may be timeless, but its structural manifestation unfolds within time. This manifestation can move within the structure, since it is actualizing itself through its own actions, realizing its own possibilities.
Henceforth, fundamentality is the degree to which a relation, like life, is directly integrated into the rope, the objective good.

Life, as a finite presence, exists within tension. It must eat, reproduce, protect, and endure. Yet, life can move out of fundamentality through its proto-soul, because the proto-soul is not reducible to biological survival. The proto-soul can align itself to what it dreams and what it is becoming, since the proto-soul is linked to existence, not life.

Where life survives, the proto-soul integrates. Where life struggles, the proto-soul can become coherent or fragment further. Agents have a soul with more reflective directness than animals, therefore agents have a more reflective soul that more dynamically coheres or fragments throughout history.

In this context, all of life has a proto-soul because all of life has a coherent external and internal presence. Life having external presence implies External Participation.

External Participation is a causal network of their bodies interacting with their environment. Life having internal presence implies that life has minds. The presence of an internal mode of control is even present in single cell organisms, since their minds are chemical reactions directing their movement throughout their whole body.

Mind is coordination. The proto-soul is the enduring responsive integration of coordinated dynamics across time. The soul is the reflective integration of this coordination, through which a being becomes capable of directing its relation to the world.

Agency comes in all shapes and sizes, in crows, in people, in bears. Agency emerges, not from life itself, but from directly integrated distortion of the objective direction. Agency came first, then through agency emerged life.

The Nature of Freedom

The fact that agency is possibility means that agency must be a coherent string of possibilities. Every deed of agency unfolds as a coherent transition within a causal sequence, like how A transitions to B. You cannot be an agent without being within the coherence of the possibilities of agency.

Imagine having the freedom to jump a fence, would you at the same moment have the agency to physically jump on the moon? No! Your agency is conditioned on what is directly next on the causal chain of events.

If you jump, then the next step is how to jump in a safe manner, or should you jump at all. Physically jumping on the moon is not an option because it will take more events to get there after jumping over the fence.

Agency requires coherence.

If one were to imagine a space of theoretical pure coherence, freedom would be one with what is coherent, for freedom is nothing without coherence. Imagine an incoherent freedom. You cannot. To have freedom is to have coherence toward something.

Yet, there is a difference between necessary coherence and achieved coherence. The rock is coherent by necessity; it does not deviate. Its path is direct because it cannot choose otherwise. Its simplicity grants stability, but not reflective depth.

To grow in fundamentality is not to lose freedom, but to gain it by becoming more coherently aligned through the navigation of deviation. Freedom is not randomness, but the integration of deviation into higher coherence through becoming more mutual to your surroundings.

Freedom is not leaving the rope, but moving along it without distortion.

This integration becomes more mutual as one ascends in mutuality. Eventually this integration becomes fully unified with everything else. A state so unified, that it is complete freedom from distortion, pain, suffering, and Evil. This implies that everything has a unified whole, which can be understood as the grounding of existence, or it can be understood more plainly as God.

Freedom is the alignment of constraint into coherence, achieved alignment to change for the sake of change-as-such, under the guidance of God. Freedom is restorative, not destructive. It is the ability to look at a knot and say NO!

We cannot be literal change in itself while we are alive, but we can reflect the goodness of change within us so that we may be coherent and free agents within existence.

I want to be fulfilled in freedom, not to lose my agency like the rock that is coherent by necessity, but to become coherent reflectively. I want to overcome my inner distortions so that when I deviate, I can return to coherence without resistance. Thus, I become free not by eliminating tension, but by integrating it. My alignment becomes long-lasting rather than short-lived fragmentation.

Seeing freedom as coherence allows one to understand why directness is objectively good. Directness aligns relations more directly to one another. When people become more coherent, they live rather than merely survive. Creativity, art, skills, passions, and love require inner integration of one's ability with one's present time in being. These are not random acts of will, but expressions of structured freedom.

Coherence guides relations toward an objective and ultimate goal. This ultimate goal is good not because I declare it so, but because everything completes toward it. What the ultimate goal is in its fullness, I do not know, for I have not achieved it.

The ultimate goal may be a personal and perfectly coherent union with God, but I will let God decide that. Yet, I can infer that this ultimate goal is mutual, creative, free, and lively. Thus, coherence gives anything, from rocks to philosophers, the ability to endure the struggles of creation according to its level, although only the agent can freely integrate those struggles toward the objective direction.

Comparing this insight of freedom to the relationship between agency and biology, we see a distinction between Respect and agency.

Respect's timelessness does not depend on time. Agency does. Respect can exist in the timeless realm; we see its effects when it coexists with the timely. Agency cannot exist without time, because no finite choice can occur without sequence. Respect is the direction. Agency is participation in that direction.

Agency is not consciousness alone; it is the ability for a thing not to be merely necessary, but to participate in direction through choice. The rock does not need agency because it cannot deviate; it is coherent by necessity within its simplicity. Life is not the same as the rock. Yet, life is not evil; it is structurally tension-bearing, placed within finitude where deviation is possible.

Therefore, lifeforms must protect one another, not merely because of sentiment, but because mutual protection strengthens integrated relations. Where relations

become more mutual, they become more stable and capable of deeper coherence. We see this in the males and females of species, and in the mutual relationships of nature, like whales being cleaned by fish while the fish receive food from the whale. Mutuality strengthens coherence. Fragmentation weakens it.

Greater coherence, is greater freedom. What is stable is the freedom to adjust yourself to be more fundamental to your surroundings. Henceforth, mutual support within the kingdom of life is not merely emotionally satisfying, but it is the bedrock of what makes us free at all.

The Flame, Termination, and Transformation

We see the strength of mutuality by looking at a humble flame. A flame in a small town goes out, and its reflection disappears. This is not defeat, but change. The relation has shifted form rather than been destroyed.

The finite will follows the same pattern. Its termination is not an end, but a passage within a larger momentum toward unity with God. What we see as change, has no effect on the essence of our will. I can look upon the art of ancient Egypt, and still be moved by those who are long gone. Their being is not within me, yet their expression still reaches me. What was formed in them remains intelligible beyond them.

Distortion exists as tension within this movement, like a knot within a rope. It does not stand apart from the whole, but interrupts its flow until it is resolved.

Extinction, decay, and death mark the limits of finite expression, not the loss of what gives it value. Coherence, as the ground of what is good, does not pass away with its temporary forms. It persists as the living relation between what was, what is, and what can be.

For the finite will, this means that neither failure nor termination has final

authority. What contradicts coherence cannot endure, while what aligns with it participates in what is lasting.

The question remains: if reality moves toward coherence, does this movement merely describe what is, or does it bind the finite will to follow it? This is the central question of Respectivism, and to answer it, we must turn to the deeper ground of reality itself.

Chapter 3

Normativity and Intentional Grounding

Respectivism begins from a simple but unavoidable point: normativity is real. When we predict, we do not obligate; we predict. Yet, agents feel and understand obligation. If obligation were forged in a fully structural universe, then obligation would be fully predictive, but it is not.

Structure makes things make sense.
Normativity makes things binding.

Therefore, when we say something ought to occur, we are not merely expressing preference. We are recognizing that reality distinguishes between coherence and fragmentation, alignment and distortion, flourishing and collapse. Normativity presents itself as binding, or unified into a singular coherent whole, instead of being statistical. The question is not whether normativity exists; the question is what makes it possible.

Structural Necessity and Normative Authority

We must first distinguish two things often confused: structural necessity and normative authority.

Structural necessity allows systems to persist. Certain configurations endure; others collapse. Organisms that accumulate too many unintegrated relations disintegrate. Buildings overloaded with misaligned complexity fall. Coherence sustains; fragmentation dissolves.

Normative authority, however, is different. It is the binding force of the 'ought.' A rock obeys gravity, but it does not recognize obligation. Coral reefs form stable ecosystems, but they do not deliberate about their arrangement.

If normativity were reducible to structure alone, every 'ought' would collapse into prediction.

So the question shifts: what gives an 'ought' its authority, if not structure alone?

Normativity Implies Structural Directness

To say 'X ought to be' is to recognize direction toward a better state, toward greater coherence.

Why does coherence relate to the good? Because coherence allows beings to persist without internal contradiction or structural collapse. If a system contains no internal contradiction, and is harmoniously integrated, then that system tends toward greater stability and flourishing. This directionality toward the good is objective, since the natural end of relations is the perfect quality of the ideal one-to-one relation.

Structural direction here is not an imagined purpose layered onto neutral matter. It is the ontological distinction between integrated continuation and structural dissolution. Life persists by increasing relational alignment. Organisms reorganize

toward coherence or collapse. Systems move toward integration or disintegrate into less ordered states.

The good is not just what persists, but what is recognized as worth preserving, even at cost to oneself.

Yet, the question remains: What gives structural direction its binding force?

Normativity Cannot Terminate in Contingency

Every contingent system derives its structure from prior conditions: biology, evolution, culture, physics. If every ‘ought’ reduces to these conditions, obligation dissolves into causal inevitability.

Even when biology strongly opposes an action—such as fasting during Ramadan—the sense of obligation can still override desire.

Authority addresses what is capable of resisting it.

Therefore, the possibility of violation does not disprove authority, it distinguishes it from structure.

Authority binds without eliminating the possibility of resistance. A person can recognize that they ought to act against instinct, in spite of physics, biology, and culture, sometimes even against what feels like the whole momentum of existence.

Therefore, the grounding of normativity cannot be merely contingent. The regress of conditional explanations must terminate in something that does not borrow authority from prior states.

Normativity requires non-contingent grounding.

If structural necessity and contingent conditions cannot ground the binding ‘ought,’ then we must ask: what kind of reality could make value and obligation truly authoritative?

Value Requires Intentional Grounding

So far, I have shown that obligation is not an illusion, and that value is not self-interpreting. Abstract structures do not command. Numbers do not enforce themselves. Logical systems remain inert unless interpreted. Mathematics describes relations, but it does not compel action. Even when mathematical truths bind inference, they do not bind conscience.

Normativity differs from abstraction precisely here: it is not merely a description of what holds, but a direction that presents itself as binding. It does not only state what is true; it presents what ought to be done. The difference is not in content alone, but in force—the difference between observed pattern and encountered authority.

Direction without address can move things forward, but it cannot bind anything to that movement.

Normativity is therefore experienced differently. The ‘ought’ does not merely indicate where things tend to go; it calls the agent into alignment with what is given. It confronts rather than predicts. Structure can remain intact regardless of recognition; normativity, by contrast, appears precisely when we encounter failure.

A pattern may organize behavior, but only what can address a will can make that organization binding. Address is not appearance. It is accountability. Accountability does not weaken when denied—it remains operative even under resistance.

One may deny that the sheep will fall from the cliff, yet the obligation to act does not dissolve with the denial. The force of that ‘ought’ does not wait for agreement;

it presents itself prior to it, and persists beyond it. It is not neutral observation—it is confrontation.

Unlike illusion, obligation does not collapse under reinterpretation. Even when re-described, it does not disappear; it reappears within the very attempt to explain it away.

In this sense, obligation is not merely recognized after the fact. It is encountered as an address to the finite will itself. And what cannot address cannot obligate.

Therefore, if normativity genuinely binds rather than merely describes or predicts, its ground must be capable of addressing will as will.

A finite will acts because it recognizes coherence and orients itself toward it. Yet, obligation is not exhausted by this recognition. It arises in the space where will stands in relation to will—where what is addressed is not structure alone, but the agent itself.

Structure can describe the path, but only intention can make it worth walking.

Authority Requires a Will

As established in this argument, an impersonal abstraction can describe relations, but it cannot address a will. A mathematical truth such as two plus two equals four is necessarily valid, yet it does not obligate a person to act. One may ignore it, misuse it, or refuse to apply it entirely.

Logical systems constrain what follows if one chooses to reason within them, but they do not command the will to reason.

Normativity, however, presents itself not as optional participation, but as binding authority. When a person recognizes that they ought to act in a certain way, the

experience is not merely that coherence would follow from the action, but that failing to act would be wrong.

This difference reveals that obligation is not merely structural alignment, but authoritative direction.

Why Reason Cannot Account for the Ought

Now I will show you how reason cannot account for the authority of the ought. Obligation involves intentional directedness toward another will, whether finite or infinite. Obligation demands; it is not "2 + 2 = 4," it is "you ought to say 2 + 2 = 4."

Logic constrains what is correct, but it does not command anyone to follow it. In essence, reason does not say "you must reason," nor does it determine when reasoning ought to occur.

This reveals a limit: logic governs consistency, but obligation governs response.

Reason depends on coherence. An argument must follow from its premises in a direct and consistent way. Yet, coherence itself does not depend on reason. The world contains directly ordered relations whether or not anyone is reasoning about them. A rock follows a trajectory without understanding it. The relation holds, but no obligation is present.

This shows that the coherence of structure can exist, in the moment, without obligation, but what about the structure itself?

If reason were the source of normativity, then recognizing what is correct would be enough to bind action. Yet, it is not. A person can understand that something is irrational and still fail to correct it. The sense that they should correct it introduces something beyond reason itself.

Thus, reason can identify order, but it cannot account for the authority that makes alignment with that order binding.

To account for that authority, something more is required—something capable of more than just structuring relations.

Consider the man and the comet. The comet moves structurally, without personality. The man, however, can choose directions and even distort the natural trajectory. If structure were ultimate, the man could not deviate—but he can.

Necessity predicts; obligation addresses. In a war zone, a man is not predicted to write, he is called to write. Structure explains explosions; it does not explain why he feels bound to answer chaos with coherence.

Deviation is experienced as rebellion, not malfunction. The ability to choose chaos does not eliminate authority; it confirms that authority addresses rather than determines. The man stands under authority so that he may obey or resist.

Obligation binds without coercing; it makes resistance meaningful.

The experience of obligation presents itself as coming from beyond the finite will. It resists reduction to desire, reasoning, or social conditioning.

Therefore, if obligation is real, it must originate in something capable of address.

Therefore, obligation requires authority, but reason alone cannot supply it with such authority.

Authority Cannot Be Finite

A finite will can address. Can this source be a finite will? No. A finite will can lose authority, conflict with other wills, or fail under conditions. Yet, obligation presents itself as unconditional and non-relative. Its grounding cannot be contingent. Finite

wills dissolve under stress, while normative authority is experienced as unconditional. The unconditional cannot be grounded in the contingent.

Emergent authority cannot explain the authority of the universe, since emergence begins somewhere. Normative authority being unconditional means it is fundamental, not emergent within reality. Collective structure also fails to explain authority: what is collective is relational, yet relation is experienced as a mode of the authority of the ‘ought’. What is a mode of something cannot be what that thing is. If causation cannot explain the authority of the ‘ought’, then structure cannot account for it.

Anything finite is dependent on something else to be what it is. This dependence makes all finite authority derivative and therefore insufficient to explain the objective and consistent authority of the ‘ought’.

Therefore, the authority of the ‘ought’ must be non-contingent and intentional. Obligation is not merely predicted within reality; it is grounded in will.

The Rope

The metaphor of the rope clarifies this. The knot experiences friction and constraint. The wind moves beyond it. Finite agency is like the knot; infinite will is like the wind. The knot may resist or align, but the wind is not constrained by it.

Within the rope, what makes the man different from the comet is that the man can existentially overcome his own knot. The comet never needs to overcome anything; it is already within the direction. The man can distort or align. That capacity reveals that structure cannot be ultimate, because it can be resisted.

The comet follows structure without awareness, nor resistance. Yet, the man stands within structure, but experiences the obligation that is blowing into it.

How does an infinite will overcome knots? Not by striving, but by its own coherent

actuality. If coherence alone cannot bind, and will alone cannot explain why the good is what it is, then the ground of normativity must unite both. Therefore, at the highest level, what is willed and what is coherent are not separate.

If normativity truly binds the will, its authority must originate in a will greater than any finite agent. This ultimate authority is Infinite Coherent Actuality.

Ideas, Time, and Stability

One way to see the stability that comes from infinite will is to look at the nature of ideas.

Ideas emerge within time because consciousness depends on time. Without time there would be no thinking, awareness, or knowledge. When a person perceives a physical object such as a mouse, the mind interacts with the changing world, and from this interaction an idea forms.

Though ideas arise through temporal experience, once formed they possess stable timeless structure, that is finite in nature. The physical mouse changes and exists in time, but the concept ‘mouse’ does not age or decay in the same way.

The man brought the idea into temporal existence, through distinction, or the potential for interaction, through his own finite willingness to do so. That potential for interaction, then developed the idea's finite, yet timeless structure.

Ideas therefore emerge from the timely, yet possess a timeless structural character.

This reveals something important: Ideas can persist beyond the conditions that generate them.

If moral realism is true, moral principles such as goodness cannot depend on time. They cannot come into being or pass away, because that would make them relative to circumstances. Yet, ideas do rely on distinctions to be physically expressed.

Therefore, moral truths must belong to the timeless and timely rather than solely the timely or timeless realms.

For ideas to reliably correspond to reality, there must be a consistency linking the timely and the timeless. This consistency cannot begin nor end within the confines of our universe's intelligibility, it is merely brought into our universe. This consistency is Respect.

Respect is the relational grammar that allows the idea of a thing to genuinely reflect that thing. It ensures coherence between thought and world.

Respect enables intelligibility and normativity, but does not ground authority.

Why Respect Is Not Ultimate

Respect explains how coherence is possible and intelligible, but it does not explain why coherence binds the will. Therefore, Respect is participatory, not ultimate.

Respect appears finite. Human beings can misunderstand, mislabel, and distort reality. If Respect fully governed all thought and being without limitation, error would be impossible, since the conditions for error would be excluded by definition. Yet mistakes occur. Therefore, Respect is not absolute in scope, but limited in its instantiation. It cannot account for the possibility of deviation from coherence; it only describes the space in which deviation becomes intelligible.

Respect is therefore a structured condition of intelligibility rather than an ultimate ground of being. It is stable in operation, but dependent in origin and participation.

This reveals its limit: Respect can preserve coherence, but it cannot generate obligation. A purely structural condition may allow intelligibility to persist, but it cannot issue a binding address to the will. It can describe what aligns, but it cannot make alignment authoritative.

Any attempt to treat logic, mathematics, or structure as ultimately self-grounding faces the same issue. Their stability presupposes invariance—conditions under which relations remain consistently interpretable. Without such invariance, no distinction between different structures could even be maintained, since "difference" itself would lose reference. Respect therefore participates in the stability of intelligibility, but does not originate as ultimate authority.

Respect makes coherence possible. It does not make coherence binding.

Therefore, Respect is not the source of normative authority, but a condition in which normativity becomes intelligible.

Teleology and the Experience of Obligation

Everything within the universe changes toward change-as-such. Matter, time, life, and energy are ordered toward increasing coherence, increasing mutuality, or oneness through their relation to change.

This suggests structural direction.

Change depends upon relation, and relation is intelligible because it participates in the possibility of perfect correspondence—the ideal one-to-one relation. This ideal relation is not merely another structure within reality; it is the limiting fulfillment toward which relations can be understood as becoming more coherent.

Teleology is this movement toward fulfillment.

All relations tend toward unity, but unity is not the destruction of distinction. The flame and its perfect reflection correspond without becoming identical. Their unity is innately relational.

And if everything obeys to be related to what interacts or not interacts with it, then there exists an end of direction, effectively a command. An identifiable direction of

relations becoming more correlated over time, since in due time, what does not get destroyed will become destroyed, and in doing so, will interact with what it hadn't before.

Even destruction requires coherence among its relations to sustain it. Even chaos requires enough coherence to be distinguishable as chaos in the first place. Incoherence cannot be ultimate, because incoherence depends upon coherence to be recognized as such.

Everything has an ‘ought’ towards the participation of coherence, mediated through their level of direct relational orientation within causation. This impacts bears, rocks, planets, galaxies, and etc. Yet, most of life is non-reflective, this means that they select, but do not recognize the ‘ought’ of their selection.

Meanwhile, humans are reflective agents, but humanity may not be the only beings capable of being reflective. We recognize the ‘ought’, feel bound to it, and can respond or resist it.

Finite obligation therefore follows the ultimate end of coherence, moral or not. This direction toward coherence is teleology, the integration of relations toward their proper alignment.

This is where teleology becomes relevant to normativity.

Teleology explains direction.

Normativity concerns what ought to be done in relation to that direction.

The deeper question is whether a finite agent is merely situated within this direction, or whether it is genuinely accountable to it.

Agency is not identical to will. Agency is the structured openness in which more than one trajectory is possible; will is the act that determines among those trajectories.

Responsibility is therefore not merely the presence of alternatives, but the condition of being answerable for selecting among them. Responsibility requires both openness and order: the agent must genuinely participate in determining its action, while the relation between action and consequence remains intelligible.

Without structured openness, responsibility collapses into necessity or chance.

Yet, coherence itself cannot mean mere coordination. A destructive system can be highly coordinated. Coherence must instead mean the fuller realization of the possibilities proper to the beings and relations involved.

This is where Respect becomes necessary.

Respect preserves distinction within relation. Without Respect, coherence could become mere assimilation; unity could destroy the very distinctions through which relations can become possible.

Respect therefore makes coherence intelligible as fulfillment rather than an horrific and ugly merger of all uniqueness into one.

Without the structure of Respect, there is no stable objective distinction between coherence and incoherence. Without that distinction, there is no basis for what is ‘better’ or ‘worse.’

A state is better insofar as it more fully realizes the relational possibilities proper to the beings and relations involved. Without ‘better,’ structured openness collapses because if one cannot achieve the relational possibilities that can make one more directly related to their surroundings, then it can be assumed that they cannot impact their surroundings on a one-to-one basis.

Therefore, any possibilities that come to them, come through an indirection to them. One stuck in this scenario would be similar to a cartoon character, they would see reality, but they cannot come to realize their own potential within reality, for they lack the agency to do so.

Hence, since we are not cartoon characters, but are instead agents. It can be inferred that normativity is therefore woven into reality itself, while morality is the finite and imperfect lens through which reflective agents interpret that normativity. We encounter objective direction through our finite understanding, which means our moral interpretations can be distorted even when the underlying normativity is not.

Yet, teleological direction still requires grounding.

Structure can describe how things relate, but it cannot by itself explain why reality has a direction that is genuinely possible.

And since a plastic sunflower on its own cannot command the universe to move toward becoming a plastic sunflower, an impersonal structure may generate convergence of everything to become a plastic sunflower but it cannot command the alignment I encounter through witnessing a plastic sunflower.

Will provides this grounding.

An infinite will of one coherent direction does not merely choose among possibilities that already exist independently of itself. This infinite will grounds the reality in which possibilities can exist at all.

A plastic sunflower can be what it is because its existence is not its own, but its possibilities are. Its journey, flourishing, and participation in further relations are possibilities within the coherent reality sustained by infinite will.

Will therefore gives direction the grounding necessary for a sunflower to be both what it is and genuinely capable of becoming what its nature allows.

Structure gives stability to responsibility by preserving the condition that more than one coherent pathway can exist under the same conditions. Responsibility does not collapse into determinism; it remains a real capacity for choice whose effects persist beyond the moment of action.

Determinism allows only one path, eliminating responsibility. Randomness allows no coherent path, dissolving responsibility. In both cases, responsibility disappears.

To experience responsibility as an addressed condition of the agent, the grounding of normativity must sustain multiple coherent trajectories within relational order.

What can maintain multiple trajectories, while still being its own?

Will.

Will has it all: agency, responsibility, and normativity. Since will includes agency, responsibility, and normativity, but it is not identical to any of them, it can be concluded that will is the source of them. For will can will to not be an agent, will to be irresponsible, and will to not obey coherence and intelligibility itself.

In this sense, will is not merely another expression of normativity; it is the capacity through which normativity becomes personally answerable.

Thus, teleological direction is neither an arbitrary command imposed upon structure nor a directionless pattern discovered after the fact.

It is the expression of one continuous intentional will.

Emergence and Its Limit

Emergence explains how new properties arise from the organization of simpler components. Wetness emerges from molecular interaction, and consciousness may emerge from neural complexity. Yet, emergent properties remain dependent on the systems that generate them.

Wetness shows us that emergent properties depend on underlying conditions. Yet, what are the underlying conditions of normative authority? If one says the rock ought to be wet or not, the authority of the ‘ought’ does not weaken or disappear.

The dependence of wetness reveals the limit of finitude: What depends on conditions cannot ground what remains binding beyond them.

Normative authority does not behave this way. The claim that one ought to act justly does not become false if no minds currently recognize it, nor does it dissolve if the conditions that gave rise to its recognition disappear. Normativity is ontologically independent of recognition, but epistemically accessed through recognition.

Emergence may explain how agents recognize obligation, but it cannot, by itself, explain its authority.

Intentional Grounding

Finally, let's explore how obligation is experienced in life. We can start with a premise we already established, that normativity cannot be reduced to structure alone. Therefore, if binding value exists, its ground must possess both authority and ontological ultimacy.

Truth from necessity cannot hold value, for value arises through relation. A man can hold onto what he values, such as a mathematical equation, yet that equation can be wrong. Although, the value of the equation does not vanish with the error, since the man cries at the failure of his own wrong equation.

If authority were structure, then truth alone would govern correction. A man would never cry to a revalued equation, for value was never lost. Yet, this is not what happens. He corrects himself not merely because structure demands it, but because he feels called beyond his current valuation. The difference is not structure, but address.

Necessity does not address failure. A rock does not call me; it simply is. Yet, failure changes me—not through mere necessity, but through my willingness to respond.

For instance, I may initiate a choice that becomes fixed in the past, but its value does not say ‘fixed.’ I may choose to eat a pizza and later judge I should have eaten lettuce instead. The action remains, but its meaning is reevaluated through my willingness to look back at what I did.

Our finite will cannot sustain total coherence. We revalue only what we attend to. Yet, the universe remains coherent. This points beyond the finite will to a ground not reducible to structure, which presents itself as authoritative and directed to us.

The same address that reveals error reveals value. Address is a non-coercive, authoritative relation in which a will is confronted by a source that exceeds it and calls it to respond, whether in alignment or resistance.

Answerability is not mere recognition of structure. It is the sense that one must respond. What does not address cannot demand a response. We are addressed without fully knowing what addresses us, and we can be corrected in ways we do not initially will.

As I am writing this, I feel the address, but do not conceive of the full consequence this answer has to the universe.

Since a self-sustaining structure cannot explain this, any response drawn from finite structure would remain internally conditioned rather than ultimately grounded. Our finite will fill in gaps within finitude to develop subjectivity instead of objectivity. Yet, when I turn toward what is more fundamental, I encounter something different. I do not construct the answer, nor fully conceive it, yet it is given.

This greater something addresses me as I am, prior to whether I understand it correctly or not. It is a relationship that is given, not produced. Thought reacts in its urge for survival, but the address does not rush like impulse, nor arise from

necessity. It is not identical to reasoning or impulse; it is that which calls before I recognize it.

Even when I am clearly wrong, the address does not disappear. What fails is not the address, but my interpretation of it. A man may put his head in a toilet to impress a girl he likes. However, the girl was not impressed. He was mistaken, yet the mistake does not mean there was no address. He responded to relational love—that is, to the address—not through reason, nor through his own uninformed but seemingly rational desires.

The evidence of address appears not in the action, but in the correction that follows. He feels, often against his own will, that he should not have done it. The address shows that my understanding is finite while the address is not. There exist moments where I do not grasp why things happen—such as why a girl does not like me—yet the sense of "I should not have done that" persists despite that uncertainty.

If the sense that I should not have done something were merely an illusion, then recognizing it as such would weaken or dissolve it. Illusions depend on belief; they lose their normative authority when explained. Yet, even when I interpret the feeling as psychology or social conditioning, it does not disappear. I may doubt it, reinterpret it, or resist it, or have it explained to me by an external source. An Atheist could try to explain the address through biological or social factors.

Yet, experience contradicts this.

If one claims that obligation is merely an illusion, that claim itself is presented as something that ought to be accepted as true rather than false. Yet this already presupposes normativity, since the distinction between truth and error carries an implicit 'ought'. A belief in which one ought to believe what is true and reject what is false.

Therefore, the denial of normativity cannot be made without implicitly appealing to it. This shows that normativity is not reducible to cognitive illusion, because even the attempt to cognitively deny it depends on its independent validity.

If normativity is not reducible to cognitive illusion, then obligated experience has real weight to it that must be taken seriously.

To understand this more clearly, we must move from abstract argument to lived experience. Normativity is not only something we reason about; it is something we encounter. The authority of the ‘ought’ is not first inferred—it is felt as binding within the structure of experience itself.

If the ‘ought’ were directly and fully related to all that is, no gap could appear between is and ought, for the two would be encountered as one.

In obligated experience, the is and the ought are not separate. The ‘ought’ is given with the force of an is. It does not appear as something added to reality, nor as a conclusion drawn from it, but as something immediately present within it. What is encountered is not a gap to be bridged, but a unity in which normative authority presents itself as part of the fabric of what is.

If the ‘ought’ were only ever derived, it would always remain conditional, dependent on prior premises. Yet, this is not how obligation appears. It confronts the will prior to full articulation, and remains binding even when one attempts to reduce it to structure or reinterpret it as illusion.

Thus, at the level of obligated experience, David Hume’s is-ought distinction does not disappear by argument, but by encounter. The ‘ought’ is lived as real before it is justified as true.

By contrast, traditional experience preserves the separation. The individual relates to what is not fully coherent, and so the ‘ought’ appears as something mediated, uncertain, or externally imposed. This gives rise to the is-ought distinction, where the mind must attempt to move from what is the case to what should be the case, yet cannot complete the movement through structure alone.

David Hume’s is-ought distinction reveals not the structure of normativity itself, only the limitation of finite participation in it.

Reconsider the earlier example: the man who puts his head in a toilet to impress someone he likes. Later, he reflects: “I should not have done that.” This is not merely a recognition of failure, but a judgment. His action is not just ineffective—it is wrong.

If judgment was structure, then it would track causal or structural conditions, and be seen differently by others, especially in the authority of the ought. Judgment would not present itself as an authority that can be recognized, ignored, or resisted independently of one's own conditions. Yet, we know that is not true.

If one were to have a conviction in their belief of something, they will hold onto their belief through storms. This does not weaken the will—it proves it. The will, finite or infinite, can sustain commitment beyond changing conditions. Without conviction, beliefs, finite or infinite, lack the ability to function as premises.

Obligation precedes the premise. One cannot hold a premise without already standing in relation—knowingly or not—to what addresses them. The address is the source of obligation from which the premise arises, experienced as judgment or reward. Thus, rational thought itself depends on prior answerability.

This judgment can arise even if no one witnessed it, and even if he believed it was the right choice at the time. The encountered error does not depend on external validation or prior belief. It presents itself as applying regardless, while remaining open to obedience or resistance.

This reveals a fundamental distinction.

A description states what is true.
A constraint limits what can occur.
But an obligation does something more: it calls for a response.

Logic can show that something is false, but it cannot make anyone correct themselves. Obligation goes further: it does not merely identify error—it presents it as something that ought to be corrected.

Thus, obligation is not merely observed; it is encountered as a demand.

The address is experienced as help rather than necessity: it calls without coercing. If the finite agent refuses correction, the failure lies in the agent, not in the address. Its honesty carries no need to preserve itself. It simply stands as binding.

What makes a demand cannot be reduced to impersonal structure. Structure can explain patterns and outcomes, but it cannot make anything matter or call anything to account.

Obligation, however, confronts the will.

It is not simply known—it addresses.

This cannot be reduced to impersonal structure, psychological conditioning, or emergent social regulation, since these accounts explain patterns of behavior but not the binding force of obligation itself. Nor can it be reduced to rational self-legislation alone, as in constructivist accounts, since obligation is encountered as already authoritative prior to reflective endorsement rather than generated through it. Nor can it be reduced to impersonal normative facts or ‘reasons’ independent of will, since these explain justification but not the experienced confrontation in which the will is held answerable.

Any account that does not involve genuine address fails to account for obligation as it is given in obligated experience.

To address is to present a claim as binding, such that it can be obeyed or resisted. This requires directedness, initiation, and normative force.

Impersonal structures possess none of these—they describe, but do not demand.

Therefore, what addresses must be capable of directed normative engagement.

Any entity capable of directed normative engagement must be able to initiate toward another and stand in relation of response.

Only will possess this capacity.

Thus, only a will can address a will.

This is why the ground of normativity cannot be structural or self-generated. It must be capable of giving, confronting, and addressing the will itself.

Yet this remains incomplete. A finite will operating within traditional experience cannot fully ground obligated experience in a coherent way, since it is limited and incomplete.

Therefore, the will that unifies the is and the ought requires an infinite will—a will lacking nothing.

The Grounds On Which Intentionality Stands

We know that the grounding of normativity is an infinite will, but not to ask why this will is as it is, is to not even attempt to see the personal side of reality. My aim is not to assume that the universe is personal, but to show that fully coherent intention leads to the conclusion that ultimate reality has a personality.

Yet, to understand how intentionality grounds normativity, we must examine the nature of the will itself. We can understand intentionality more fully by examining the finite and infinite expressions of the will, which we can understand in terms of personality.

As stated before, infinity is completeness, the absence of lack. A fully coherent will is a fully coherent being. Personality, in this sense, is the expression of that one end point of coherence as intention. Address is not from separate personalities because if that was so then why is address always felt as address?

If the universe was ruled by multiple personalities, then the address to me would contradict itself and become unintelligible within the moment. That never happens, since the address happens, and is intelligible no matter if we want it or not. Therefore, when we understand coherence as directly self-related and self-expressive rather than merely structural, it constitutes what is meant by intentional subjectivity or personality, independent of any finite or multiplied form. The personality is one.

Coherence is self-expressive through being expressed as a standard that is consistent, yet varied. Our existence is numerous within a state of order. This order cannot just be there, since it is there. The contingency of existence cannot be explained by existing, it must have a deeper meaning. And that meaning is intention.

The important point is that intention is not something added onto normativity after the fact. Normativity is already intentional in its very form.

A descriptive fact tells us what is.

A structural fact tells us how things relate.

A normative fact tells us what ought to be.

Yet, an ought is not merely another description of reality. When I encounter the claim that I ought not torture an innocent person, I do not merely encounter another property of the world. I encounter a “no.” The wrongness presents itself as something directed toward me, something that calls for a response.

I can obey it, resist it, deny it, or reinterpret it. Yet, each of these responses occurs in relation to what has presented itself as binding.

If I recognize that I ought not torture an innocent person and nevertheless choose to do the opposite, I have not escaped from this normative claim. My refusal is itself a

response to what I deny. To act as though the torture is permissible is to affirm, through my will, that the will supersedes the claim and not the other way around.

Therefore, obligation cannot be merely a fact that exists without relation to a will. Its normativity consists precisely in the way it stands before a will as something to which the will is answerable to.

This is why normativity cannot be reduced to an impersonal normative fact. An impersonal fact can be true, but truth alone does not address. A rock can be true to its structure. A mathematical relation can be necessarily valid. A proposition can be logically entailed. Yet, none of these, considered merely as structures, says to a will, “Do not do this.”

The ought does.

The normative “no” is not merely something I observe. It confronts me, it is ugly and beautiful, all at the same time.

This is why God is not merely the being who happens to know normative truths. God is the truth in which the normative claim is grounded. When we encounter something as wrong, we encounter a “no” that is felt as binding. God addresses, and we simply respond to His address.

The response does not create the obligation. The obligation precedes the response.

This is also why denying an obligation does not make it disappear. If I deny that I ought not torture an innocent person, I have not shown that there was never an obligation. I have responded to it through resistance. The will cannot step outside the relation of answerability simply by refusing to answer rightly.

Therefore, the normative fact is not merely a proposition waiting to be discovered. It is a truth that addresses.
Address is the intentional directedness of truth toward a will.

This is the point at which intention becomes necessary. Intention is not merely the ability to have a thought about something. It is the ability for what one is to be directed toward what one wills. A will does not merely bounce around like rocks in space; it directs itself as itself.

To address is to present something as requiring a response. This requires directedness, initiation, and normative force. The address is not merely that something occurs to me. It is that something is being given to another as something that matters personally to that will.

This is why a rock differs from a will. A rock can affect me, but it cannot address me because it possesses no intention. If my address was a rock it could fall toward me, strike me, or change my environment, but none of these events would be intelligible as being personal to me.

Why is this so? It is so because to be personal is to be presented as a claim that cannot be avoided, for the will within me becomes linked in a way that unconsciously is known as a claim that I instinctually try to resist.

The oneness of the source of the address gives this source a scary sense of authority and its normative power that we feel within us.

Henceforth, a will can address another will because both possess the intention to do so.

The Codyverse and the Personal Ground of Reality

The Codyverse makes this distinction visible. If I choose to change an outcome within the Codyverse, that outcome changes according to my will. To those inside the Codyverse, my action might appear as moral obligation, random happenstance, or simply, “What is happening?” Yet, from my perspective, it is intentional. It is my will acting upon the Codyverse that I created.

I remember the characters inside the Codyverse, such as Robot Mewtwo. He could experience my action for him without knowing its source. Robot Mewtwo tended to misunderstand my address completely and yet Robot Mewtwo was still genuinely affected by it. The lack of his understanding does not eliminate my intention for him to be the main foe within the Codyverse. Any of the interpretations of the characters of the Codyverse could be wrong while the unique addresses for them all remain real.

This reveals something important about the idea of divine address.

The finite will does not create the address merely by recognizing it. The address comes first, and then recognition follows. We are addressed before we fully understand what addresses us.

This is why intention unifies the “is” and the “ought.” The “is” concerns what something is; the “ought” concerns what should be. Intention connects them by directing what something is toward what is meant to be.

To encounter intention is consequently to encounter something descriptive capable of producing an ought.
In essence, a will does not merely describe what is. It can direct what is toward what it intends.

This does not mean that every intention is morally good. A finite will can intend incoherence, distortion, or destruction. Rather, intention provides the form through which an actuality can be directed toward a fulfillment. The great question concerns whether that intention participates in complete coherence or not.

Therefore, intention alone is not yet the fullness of normativity. A finite will can intend wrongly. What normativity requires is intentionality united with truth and coherence.

This is why the ultimate ground cannot be merely will in the sense of arbitrary choice. A will without coherence would be arbitrary, while coherence without will would be non-binding.

The ground that makes existence possible must therefore unite both.
I say that this ground is an infinite personality, since an infinite personality possesses complete coherence within its own will. It is one, for it lacks nothing. This ability to lack nothing includes not lacking in having complete obligation as fulfillment, for it is the unified source of obligation.

Ultimate coherence has personality because its coherence is not arbitrary. Everything can be identified, and therefore there must be some ground that makes it so. If such grounding exists and it is not arbitrary, then it cannot be random, for how could randomness lead to the enduring coherent order that our universe proclaims?

It is self-evident that such grounding is not merely coherent, but truthful in the sense that it is to be as it does. What does this look like in practice?

Obligation.

An obligation that addresses us, because we are not yet full to it, and it knows because it addresses us as so, by its nature as the grounding of existence, or simply endless intention. Therefore, what is fulfilled must ought to be so, since fulfillment without obligation is not only meaningless, but against the grounding of intention itself. If there is no means to ascend or be ascended, then there is no intention of such filling to be done in such a being. If this is so, then this fulfillment has already ended at a singular state of coherent unity.

Therefore, it possesses a completely fulfilled being that can be understood as a coherent personality. Yet, I am my own being; I cannot see what the rocks, birds, people, and animals see. So, the universe is full of oughts because I ought to become what calls me to be.

When people imagine personality, they imagine finite personality, our lived, limited selves. The infinite will does not have that; it has infinite personality. Our human failures, incoherent quirks, cultural upbringing, and impersonal structures like our brain chemistry shape our finite personalities.

By necessity, finite personalities are defined by what they lack. A man may be funny and cool, yet by that very fact, he lacks the qualities that would make him unfunny or lame. All distortion belongs to finite participation.

Unlike finite personalities, an infinite personality contains all positive qualities in perfect harmony. The infinite will is self-identical with coherence, whose being and willing are one and the same. Its being is an eternal self-expressing act that we describe as independent will.

What is free is expressed by how coherent one is to the goal they desire. An infinite will is free as the self-expression of perfect coherence that grounds existence without being a part of it. Without this coherence, it would not be sovereign.

The infinite will is sovereign, for if the house of structure was never built, then how could there be structure? A house cannot build itself; structure cannot originate itself.

Yet, the deeper issue is not merely structure, but actuality itself.
Mathematics describes relations, but mathematics requires objects or realities to be expressed through. Truth also cannot stand alone, because truth must always be true of something. Logic explains coherence between propositions, yet propositions themselves require actuality in order to exist at all.

Thus, impersonal abstractions are not self-grounding. They depend upon something beyond themselves in order to be expressed.

What is ultimate, however, cannot require what it is not. If ultimate reality depended upon logic, mathematics, truth, or structure in order to exist, then those things would be more fundamental than ultimate reality itself.
Therefore, ultimacy cannot terminate in abstraction or structure alone. It must terminate in what exists directly through itself.

Only a direct relation can do this.

A direct relation possesses no greater sum behind it. It is not assembled from prior parts or derived from external conditions. Its actuality is identical with its self-expression, for it is pure correlation. It is not built, but it is. Within direct relation is causality itself, because cause and effect unfold through direct participation rather than detached abstractions such as thought.

Will is present from this ultimacy of direct relation, since directness is, by its nature, expressive as its own being. There is no sum behind infinite will that explains it through something more basic.

Infinite will is Infinite Coherent Actuality itself. Therefore, will becomes self-grounding at infinity because will is the doing and the description at the same time. So, God's will is what God is. This is different from a finite will which depends upon conditions outside itself, but an infinite will lacks nothing outside itself and therefore exists through its own coherent actuality alone.

This is what is meant by infinite personality.

Personality here does not mean finite psychological traits or human quirks. It means coherent self-expression through direct self-related being. The infinite will is not constructed from structure, but is the actuality through which structure becomes possible at all.

Thus, God does not require logic, mathematics, truth, or even reality as something beyond Himself in order to exist. Rather, logic expresses coherence, mathematics expresses intelligible relation, and truth expresses actuality in correspondence with itself. Yet, all of these already presuppose actuality.

Only direct self-related actuality can be ultimate.

Therefore, if reality is grounded in direct relation rather than impersonal abstraction, ultimate reality must be personal because only intention can supersede logic and mathematics by being different from them, while still possessing the capacity to recreate them. Infinite coherent will is the self-grounding actuality

through which causality, intelligibility, normativity, and structure become possible at all.

The strongest objection one might make to this personal view of reality is whether God faces the same problem of needing a grounding to his personality. Yet, the infinite will is not merely another being requiring a further explanation of its actuality. To will requires only the intention of the will.

God, as Infinite Coherent Actuality, is not a becoming among becomings, but the ultimate coherence that grounds all becoming. His being is His willing, and His willing is His being. Therefore, He does not borrow actuality from something beyond Himself. He is actuality itself.

Therefore, the question is not merely what the house is, but what willed it into existence?

No power of authority can change what this question presupposes. This is the moment where Friedrich Nietzsche would be joyful and horrified at the same time. God is not dead! God is perfectly coherent becoming—not as lack, but as the self-expression of His infinite will. This becoming is the infinite will's own personality, its own self-expression, experienced as beyond the temporal limits of consciousness, grounded in its own intentional actuality.

Consciousness is constrained by cause and effect. Actuality is what is; it is independent of temporal consciousness and dependence and, through its objectivity, creates the only form of true independence, known to us as free will.

Consciousness requires what it is to correlate to the subject. It is associated with the finite will. This limitation of the finite being in encapsulating the infinite will's complete expression creates a gap between what consciousness is and what the subject is. Therefore, the finite will lacks a fully free will, while the infinite will is fully free, and that is a comforting thought, since reality is taken care of, and I don't have to carry that burden myself.

Therefore, one can be certain that actuality is more free than consciousness because there is no gap between what is actual and what is intentional. It is a freedom so coherent that it is both the most ordered force possible and the most free force possible. Within this freedom of actuality, the infinite will is the end in which all becoming ends, where becoming exists within its own positive ultimate ability.

In this positive ultimate ability, the infinite will, by being what it is, determines what is below it. All that is incomplete depends on what is complete to be what it is at all. We see incoherence, but incoherence cannot ground anything. Only coherence—existence itself—can ground what exists.

I can clearly imagine this. When I was in 5th grade, I imagined a world called the Codyverse. Many rejected it by saying that it was not real, that it was fake, and that it was merely what I thought and nothing more. Let's test that hypothesis: was this mental world governed by the structure of my brain? If my mental world arose through necessity, then exact versions of it would have arisen within the minds of others, especially in the minds of those bullies, under the same conditions. Yet, no one but me has this personal world in their mind in the exact way as I had it.

The coherence, correction, and intelligibility of the Codyverse behave as though it all originated in a unified source of address, which is me. The Codyverse shows how coherence can arise from will. Yet, our world does not merely display coherence—it confronts us with obligation every day. Where my imagined world depends on my will for its structure, the real world exceeds its own structure by addressing us.

I can experience that I should start to imagine the Codyverse, even when it does not serve my immediate desire. I also experience that I should help pick up trash on the side of a road, even when I don't want to do it. In the Codyverse, the address originates from me. In the real world, the address confronts me as not my own. The form is similar, but the source is not. If the address I encounter is not reducible to my own will, yet still binds me as authoritative, then its source must exceed any finite will.

Imagine that in our world this ‘me’ did not exist. How then could coherence, correction, and intelligibility come about? If coherence were merely structural, it could describe relations but not correct them as binding. In essence, how can existence ground itself as such without anything to hold onto?

The simple answer is that it cannot.

A finite will can resist what addresses it, but only for a moment, and only within limits it does not control. What is ultimate has no such limit. It is not resisted from outside itself, for there is nothing beyond it. Even resistance arises within its ground of being.

Therefore, the Codyverse did not arise by necessity, but through my willingness to imagine it. Yet, I could only sustain it for a short time before my brain grew tired. An infinite will would not have this limitation; it would continuously will everything without lack. Its infinite will would be indistinguishable from our own reality.

In the Codyverse, I am not only a character, but a hero. Yet, I am not identical to my character. I let my character act freely, yet everything that happens still occurs through my willingness for it to be. It is a weird experience to imagine to be actuality. Yet, what my imagination reveals is the truth of existence: Will creates; structure legitimizes. I am the fundamental will that holds the Codyverse together.

If I can form a world like this, then a will far greater than mine could sustain a world far more coherent and real than I ever could.

Our universe is complex and extremely dynamic. What grounds such a world cannot be a finite will that has the possibility to fail to implement the fundamental rules of reality. No scientist has ever seen the speed of light change in any space within reality. If our universe was ruled by a finite will, a universal speed would be impossible to maintain everywhere. I know, the Codyverse cannot have such a universal speed limit, my memory is too weak to maintain such an exact parameter. Therefore, the will that sustains us must be sufficient to sustain all coherence and

all obligation without lack. A will so vast and powerful of this kind is indistinguishable from what we call God.

Therefore, we are in the personal will of an infinite will rather than a strong but limited finite will.

Divine Goodness, Address, and Love

This also illuminates the Euthyphro problem.

If goodness were external to the infinite will, then the infinite will would not be ultimate, because its willing would depend upon a standard more fundamental than itself. Yet, if goodness were merely whatever the infinite will arbitrarily commanded, then normative authority would have no ground beyond command itself.

Within Infinite Coherent Actuality, this separation does not hold. Will and coherence are one actuality. The infinite will does not conform to an external standard of goodness, nor does it arbitrarily create goodness through command. Its willing is the self-expression of its own perfect coherence.

This infinite will cannot ultimately will against its own perfect coherence. What it wills expresses what it is. If God's willing is identical with perfect coherent actuality, then divine action cannot be understood as arbitrary self-preference. Instead, divine action is the expression of His fullness rather than compensation for some theoretical deficiency of His own will.

Therefore, goodness is neither an external standard imposed upon God nor an arbitrary decree. Goodness is the expression of the coherent nature of Infinite Coherent Actuality.

Coherence without will can describe alignment, but cannot address a will. Will without coherence could command, but could not provide a non-arbitrary ground for goodness. In Infinite Coherent Actuality, these are unified.

Coherence gives the will its objective character; will gives coherence its intentional character. God is not encountered as a new equation; He is encountered like a newly discovered flower. He is a subject to move with, not for.

Therefore, normative authority is grounded in the unity of perfect coherence and infinite will.

His presence is why correction is possible, why error is detectable, and why the world we call home is more coherent than the Codyverse.

Yet, as a character within creation. I must ask: So, why me? Why address me? God could leave me alone; He could move on towards someone else, and what would be the difference? I can only do so much, and He can do everything that I cannot.

To visualize this, we need to go back to the Codyverse. Why do I address Robot Mewtwo? I mean, I could choose myself within the Codyverse; I could myself be selfish, but I am not. I address Robot Mewtwo to be the foe. Why do I do that?

When I dig deeper into why I choose Robot Mewtwo, it is clear to me that it is the same reason why I ground the existence of Robot Mewtwo in the first place. I love him. I love to see what Robot Mewtwo will do. I love the scene in the same way that I love the scene of "Luke, I am Your Father." in *Star Wars: The Empire Strikes Back*. I like a great story, and I will Robot Mewtwo to undertake that story.

Why would I love a finite villain in a world I could delete in an instant, and make it better than before? Why do I keep Robot Mewtwo consistently as he is for a decade of imagining the Codyverse? I do it because what makes Robot Mewtwo particular is his entire history, from birth to death.

If Robot Mewtwo was different, then I would lose something. It would not affect me physically, mentally, or even spiritually. But, it would affect who I am. That can

be felt even when you are Infinite Coherent Actuality itself, since to process a personality, finite or infinite, is to be someone. To lose a particular aspect of you that you built, even if it is not literally you, will hurt. In the same way how a person who has seen Avengers Endgame for the second or third time doesn't like seeing Thanos winning in Avengers Endgame. A perfect, all-powerful, and all-knowing being would not like seeing their particular creation suffer, especially when that suffering prevents it from reaching what creation ought to grow to be.

Does this mean I am too strict to Robot Mewtwo when I address him? No. I address him and I see what follows, and enjoy it nonetheless, since it is my will after all. I am starting to see a similar situation with me and God. God addresses me because His intention is that He loves me. He is not wanting me to be a foe, for I am not as loving as He is, but nonetheless I feel that I must continue to explain why. That is the address I am encountering while writing this paragraph. I am encountering a call to help others, not because it is just good, but because it is meaningful.

Imagine being infinite and perfect, what would interest you? What you are, or what you are not? It would be what you are not, since what you are not is imperfect and therefore limited in its access to your fullness. It is a call to help; that is the intent of the address that always is felt, what happens afterwards is how our finite will deals with it.

God does not attempt to make us morally right; He attempts to make us ontologically full, beyond morality, beyond our problems, and beyond ourselves towards the coherence of Him. Our coming to His coherence is what makes God happy, just like how I am happy when I fight against Robot Mewtwo. God likes existential romance, and I like epic action and explosions. Yeah, I can see how we can get along.

A Personal Assessment On The Necessity of Faith

I have concluded that intentional grounding is the best explanation as to why we have obligation in a sea of structure. So, what follows is not a further proof, but a reflection on what this means for lived experience.

For even if the argument is sound, something can still be missing.

While finishing this inquiry, I was at a Christian concert with thousands of people, and I noticed something. Even though I believed I have discovered proof of an infinite will that governs the universe, I was not crying out like the others were. Many of them had no knowledge of my proof, yet they expressed something I did not.

I looked around in awe. We are finite beings trying to understand an infinite will. Yet, to fully understand an infinite personality with a finite mind is impossible. Even at such impossible odds, thousands of people were trying to do it anyway. This reveals a limit.

To know that an infinite will exists is not enough.

I can know that something exists without knowing its True Purpose, its integration to the rope, or its unity of dream and action. I may see a ground mole in my yard (world) and recognize that it is there, moving with the objective direction. Yet, even in this simple case, I do not fully know why it does what it does.

Now imagine that the ground mole is not finite, but infinite.

If the being I observe possesses an infinite will, then its True Purpose cannot be exhausted by my understanding. No matter how much I observe, I cannot fully grasp the depth of its intention. Its actions always exceed my explanation, because my explanation is my dream, not the infinite ground mole's dream.

If the ground mole were infinite, then its purpose would forever surpass me. And if even the slightest incoherence in my understanding distorts what I perceive, then I cannot rely on comprehension alone to align myself with it.

Because of this, I should learn from the masses at the Christian concert, not by abandoning reason, but by recognizing the limit of finite reasoning. I must surrender to my inability to know, and receive the comfort it brings.

This is where faith becomes necessary, even with rational proof.

I should have faith that I can move toward the Infinite Coherent Actuality, even though my finitude restricts me from fully knowing it. Normativity remains grounded, not because I fully comprehend the infinite, but because I can recognize its coherent direction.

I do not know a ground mole's personality, but I do know that it lives in my yard (world). The same is true with the Infinite Coherent Actuality. I know that the Infinite Coherent Actuality is present in my yard (world), yet even so, His own personality within infinity is beyond my understanding.

We may not reach the top, but we can see the edges.

And that is enough to move.

If one rests entirely on reasoning to know the infinite will, one remains silent among those who are filled with joy. Understanding alone is not participation.

Do I want to be quiet when everyone else is joyful? No! What a waste of a life!

Therefore, I must use what is given to me, the objective direction, to have faith that I can overcome my finitude, to get closer to the infinite will who rules all.

If this infinite will is truly coherent and infinite, then everything must ultimately lead to it. Faith, then, becomes a way to lift our finite preferences toward the coherence of the infinite will. I may not know where I am going, but I can see the crowd moving, and if everyone is heading somewhere, I want to know why?!

Reason can show that normativity governs reality.

Yet, faith is what makes life worth living. Faith lifts people up, not through their labor alone, but through their forgiveness of their own finite limits.

We must overcome the fact that we cannot fully know the infinite will, so that we can move closer to it. This creates a continual cycle: each step brings us nearer to the infinite will, a continual ascent toward greater independence from everything else through increasing coherence with our surroundings.

Therefore, to have faith, is to move towards coherence despite finitude. To be free is worth nothing, if I cannot have an end goal to being free towards.

That end goal is faith, to bulldoze towards coherence against all odds.

The Ordered Progression

I. The Reality of Normativity

1. Normativity exists.
2. Agents distinguish between what is and what ought to be.
3. An ought is not a prediction.
4. A prediction describes what will happen.
5. An obligation concerns what should happen.
6. An ought is not merely a preference.
7. An agent can reject an obligation while still recognizing it.
8. Therefore, normative authority is not identical to subjective preference.

9. An obligation can be violated without ceasing to bind.

10. Therefore, obligation is not identical to causal necessity.

11. Causation explains what follows from prior conditions.

12. Obligation concerns what an agent should do.

13. Normativity therefore differs from structural necessity.

14. Structure explains what follows.

15. Normativity concerns what ought to be followed.

II. Normativity and Answerability

16. Obligation concerns an agent as an agent.

17. It presents an action as something the agent should respond to.

18. To be obligated is therefore to be answerable.

19. Answerability is different from mere constraint.

20. A wall can constrain movement without holding anyone accountable.

21. Obligation remains authoritative even when the agent resists it.

22. Answerability therefore involves a relation.

23. An agent is answerable to something.

24. This relation is what I call address.

25. Address presents something to an agent as requiring a response.

26. Obligation therefore has an addressive structure.

27. The agent does not merely encounter information.

28. The agent encounters a claim upon the will.

III. Why Impersonal Structure Cannot Address

29. Impersonal structures can describe relations.

30. They can also constrain what occurs.

31. They do not, by themselves, intentionally address an agent.

32. A rock can affect a person without addressing that person.

33. Causal influence is therefore not the same as address.

34. A mathematical truth can be necessary without addressing anyone.

35. A logical relation can be valid without commanding anyone.

36. Truth and address must therefore be distinguished.

37. Something can be true without intentionally confronting a will.

38. An impersonal normative fact could therefore be true without explaining answerability.

39. The existence of normative truth does not by itself explain normative authority.

40. The problem is not only whether an ought is true.

41. The problem is why a will is answerable to it.

42. Therefore, the ultimate ground of obligation must explain answerability, not structure.

IV. From Answerability to Will

43. Answerability requires a relation between the agent and what addresses it.

44. Address requires directedness toward a recipient.

45. Directedness requires more than passive existence.

46. It requires intentional orientation.

47. Will is the capacity for intentional orientation toward an end.

48. Here, will does not mean emotion or impulse.

49. It means intentional directedness.

50. Therefore, a genuine address requires will-like intentionality.

51. The ground of normative address must therefore possess intentionality.

52. Normativity cannot be fully grounded in structure alone.

53. Structure without intentionality can describe relations.

54. It cannot itself constitute an intentional address.

V. Why Finite Will Cannot Be Ultimate

55. A finite will is contingent.

56. It exists under conditions it did not establish.

57. A contingent will cannot be the ultimate ground of its own authority.

58. Finite wills can also conflict.

59. Agreement among finite wills can explain convention.

60. Convention does not create ultimate necessity.

61. Disagreement does not destroy objective normativity.

62. Therefore, finite wills cannot by themselves ground unconditional authority.

63. Emergent wills face the same problem.

64. An emergent will depends upon conditions that produce it.

65. A dependent source cannot be the ultimate ground of what is unconditional.

66. Therefore, the ultimate ground of normativity must be non-contingent.

VI. Respect, Structure, and Teleology

67. Coherence is required for stable intelligibility.

68. Without coherence, distinctions could not remain stable.

69. The relational stability that permits intelligibility is what I call Respect.

70. Respect makes coherent distinction possible.

71. Respect does not itself create normative authority.

72. It explains how coherence can be recognized.

73. It does not explain why coherence binds the will.

74. Structure also provides direction.

75. Direction toward an end is teleology.

76. Teleology explains ordered movement toward fulfillment.

77. Teleology does not by itself explain obligation.

78. An agent can recognize an end and still resist it.

79. Therefore, direction is not identical to authority.

80. Structure explains coherence.

81. Teleology explains direction.

82. Neither alone explains answerability.

VII. Teleology, Agency, and Responsibility

83. Teleology concerns the movement of relations toward fulfillment, but does not, by itself, explain obligation.

84. Fulfillment is not mere coordination, since a destructive system can also be coordinated.

85. We are not obligated to be worse, we are obligated to be better.

86. A state is better insofar as it more fully realizes the relational possibilities proper to the beings and relations involved.

87. Agency is the structured openness in which more than one trajectory is possible.

88. Will is the act that determines among those trajectories.

89. Responsibility requires both genuine participation in choosing and intelligible relations between action and consequence.

90. Without structured openness, responsibility collapses into necessity or chance.

91. Therefore, teleological direction alone does not establish either responsibility, agency, or normativity on its own.

92. Since responsibility, agency, and normativity need each other, but cannot ground each other, and structure fails to adequately explain all three.

93. It can be concluded that an ultimate will must sustain coherent possibilities while grounding the teleological direction toward the fulfillment of responsibility, agency, and normativity, all at once.

94. Therefore, teleology, agency, and responsibility require an account of intentional will.

VIII. The Experience of Obligation

95. Normativity is not merely a description of what happens.

96. In obligated experience, the ought is encountered as binding, even when resisted or misunderstood.

97. The is–ought distinction is encountered through the limitation of finite participation: the agent experiences a gap between what is and what ought to be.

98. Therefore, if structure cannot explain the why of the universe, then why would structure explain what of this universe.

99. A missing link is not evidence of success, but evidence that we are missing something about reality when we look at it through solely structure.

IX. Why the Ground Must Be Coherent

100. The ultimate ground must be intentional.

101. But intention alone is insufficient.

102. A will can intend something incoherent.

103. An arbitrary will cannot provide a non-arbitrary ground of goodness.

104. Therefore, will alone cannot ground ultimate normativity.

105. The ultimate ground must also possess perfect coherence.

106. Coherence alone is also insufficient.

107. Coherence can describe relations without addressing a will.

108. Therefore, coherence alone cannot ground normative authority.

109. Will and coherence are each insufficient by themselves.

110. Will provides intentional address.

111. Coherence prevents that address from being arbitrary.

112. Therefore, ultimate normative authority requires their unity.

X. From Coherent Will to Ultimate Actuality

113. The ultimate ground cannot depend upon something more fundamental.

114. Anything dependent is not ultimate.

115. Therefore, the ultimate ground must be self-grounding.

116. An abstraction cannot be self-grounding in this sense.

117. Mathematics describes relations between realities.

118. Logic describes relations of consistency.

119. Truth is truth of something.

120. Structure is structure of something.

121. Therefore, abstractions presuppose actuality.

122. The existence of contingent reality and its intelligible order raises the question of what ultimately grounds their actuality, which cannot be explained merely by describing what exists.

123. The ultimate ground must therefore be actuality rather than a mere abstraction.

124. Its existence cannot be borrowed from something beyond itself.

125. Its actuality must therefore be identical with its own self-expression.

126. A self-grounding actuality cannot lack the coherence required for its own existence.

127. Therefore, the ultimate actuality must be perfectly coherent.

128. It must also be intentional.

129. Thus, the ultimate ground is a self-grounding coherent will.

XI. Why the Ground Is Infinite

130. The ultimate ground cannot depend upon a condition outside itself.

131. It therefore lacks external limitation.

132. What is limited by something beyond itself is not ultimate.

133. The ultimate ground therefore lacks nothing required for its own actuality.

134. Complete actuality is not finite in the ordinary sense.

135. It does not possess its being as a partial participation in something greater.

136. It possesses actuality through itself.

137. Therefore, the ultimate ground is complete rather than finite.

138. I call this completeness infinity.

139. The ultimate ground is therefore infinite.

XII. Infinite Coherent Actuality

140. The ultimate ground is non-contingent.

141. It is intentional.

142. It possesses will.

143. It possesses perfect coherence.

144. It is self-grounding.

145. It is ultimate actuality.

146. It is not an impersonal abstraction.

147. It is capable of intentional address.

148. It therefore explains why obligation can confront a finite will.

149. Coherence gives its authority an objective character.

150. Will gives that authority intentional direction.

151. Their unity provides a non-arbitrary ground for normativity.

152. Therefore, the ultimate ground of normativity is Infinite Coherent Actuality.

153. Infinite Coherent Actuality is what we call God.

Conclusion

This whole philosophical project develops the philosophy of Respectivism, the philosophical grounding of my wonderful work: *The Partaceyist Statement*.

The universe is vast and wide, and I cannot conclude everything, but I can sum up the essence of everything. I may not be able to go where the crowd goes, but I can follow where they go. And where they go is the Hierarchy of Fundamentality, the

degrees of participation in coherence, from its most deviated state to its ultimate actuality.

At the most incoherent level of chaos and disorder lies Evil. War, violence, and tragedy exist in this level, but they are constantly changing form, due to their incoherent nature. What is Evil is as far from the infinite will as existence gets. It exists because it depends on everything else to be actualized; it is a lack of coherent participation in what is greater than it.

Evil depends on agency. Agency is not the will. Agency is a field of possibility that can be coherent or incoherent. It defines the growth or fall of the universe. Evil is dependent on agency, because Evil is solely incoherence, while agency is not.

Agency requires change. Change is the means in which things unfold. No amount of agency could challenge the dominance of change. Agency can die, but its change never dies. Agency requires a medium in which alternatives can unfold, and this medium is change itself. This implies that the will is not agency. Agency is the field of possible directions; will is the act that determines among them.

Change presupposes the ideal one-to-one relation. The ideal one-to-one relation is the relation that change depends on to be unfolded as such. It is the limiting case of perfect correspondence between cause and effect, the condition that makes all partial and imperfect relations intelligible as relations at all. Without the ideal one-to-one relation, relation would not be possible, which change depends on to unfold in time.

The ideal one-to-one relation presupposes Respect. The concept that gives Respectivism its name. Respect is finite and timeless, created by God, and brought into our universe. Respect is finite in that it is not self-grounding, yet timeless in that its structural role does not change across time.

Respect is a realm where ideas that emerge in time, develop their own stable timeless structure. Respect develops the intelligibility of idealized cause and effect, through its coexistence between the timely and the timeless. Without Respect, there is no intelligibility of relation, yet different forms of this structure can exist in

different universes. Respect is the structure that gives anything of distinguishable order in our universe a place to be distinguished as such.

Finally, Respect presupposes God, or the infinite will. The infinite will is coherence itself. To not be actual in direct cause, is to not be willed at all. God simply exists, and His existence makes the multiverse intelligible through His Logos. Without the infinite will, Respect cannot be willed into being, to start being coherent as the structure of Respect.

The finite will is this power filtered through Respect, into coherent finite individuality. Yet, the infinite will is the state in which all comes together. Its coherence is fundamentally good, for without coherence, there is no foundation for what could be beneficial to others. The infinite will gives us that foundation to experience and witness benefit. Therefore, to deviate from this infinite will, is to fall into incoherence.

Respectivism is both metaphysical and existential. If one were to rip away a person's time, matter, and identity, what would remain? What remains is not atoms, but the very condition that made such removal possible: will itself. The ought of the intention that grounds the very act of erasing in the first place. Therefore, to contradict the erasing is to not erase the person at all. The person is not reducible to what can be removed, but is grounded in the infinite will that makes removal possible at all.

Structure is the condition of intelligibility.

Intention is the source of authority.

Becoming is participation.

And participation is everything, because the intention calls us to do it.

This is not just a description of the universe. It is the situation we find ourselves in.

Respect might be the order of structure, but will is the means to which order can ever be realized. An order without will is nothing, for what can be consistent without the means to be expressed, as independent of that consistency, outside of the infinite will.

I can only imagine that an infinite will looks at the universe, and grounds the relation we experience as respect, since all cause and effect unfolds in direct relation. The essence of everything is participation in coherent relation, which is existentially experienced to the finite will as respectful. This experience of the respectful—from will, through structure, to the finite agent—is the whole point of Respectivism.

Thus, what we experience as obligation is the finite encounter with infinite coherence, calling us toward participation in what ultimately is.